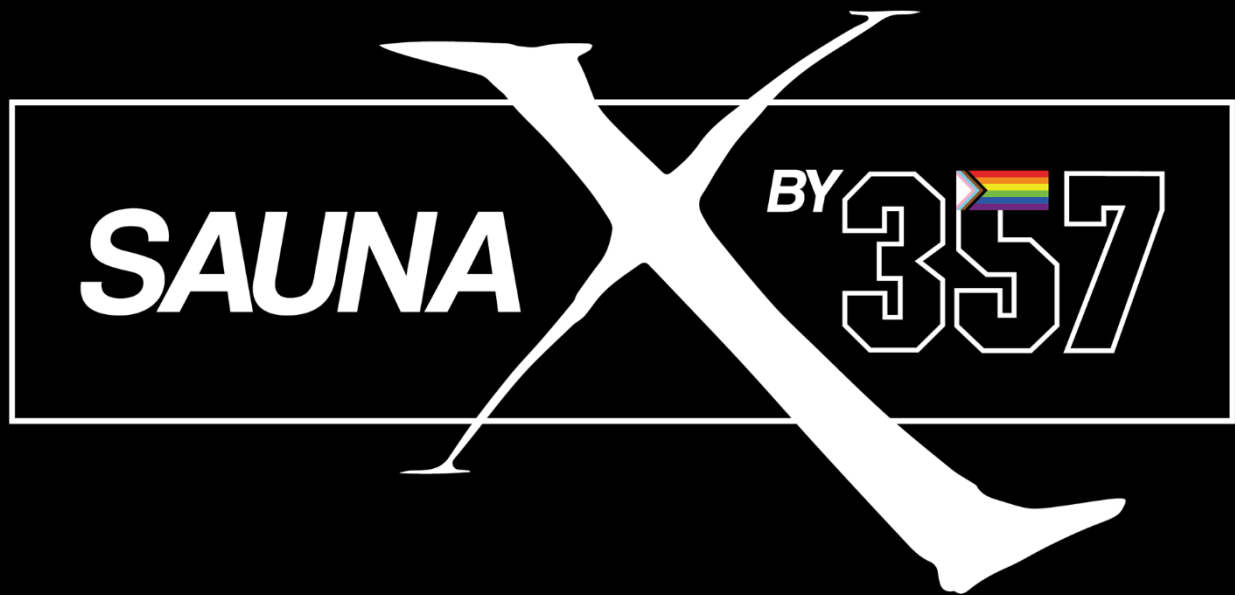




**Selling sex in the city:
is gay Sydney wanting more?**

PROJECT REPORT

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24790 Business Project: Marketing (Capstone)
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University of Technology Sydney (UTS)

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

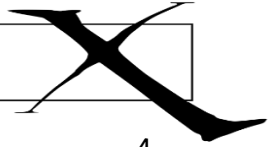


This research project has been conducted by a postgraduate university student at the University of Technology Sydney (UTS) into the business model of Sauna X by 357 and investigates the needs of customers of sex on premises venues to identify what criteria is used by gay men in choosing the sex on premises venue over any of the other competitors in the market.

Combining both qualitative and quantitative primary data collected by interviewing staff and surveying customers, with secondary data gathered by a thorough literature review of existing conceptual frameworks and marketing theories, this report offers a deeper understanding into the reasons why gay men go to sex on premises venues, the factors that influence their preference of venue and the relevance of the individual amenities provided that contribute to the customer experience.

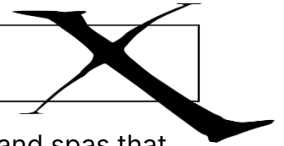
By analysing the results of this research, this report offers recommendations for Sauna X to avoid making the mistakes made by the previously failed Bodyline brand and to improve how it sells sex in the city, by applying the knowledge learned that answers whether gay men in Sydney now want more than they did before, to the Sauna X business model and their marketing strategies moving forward.

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INTRODUCTION



Sex on premises venues are adult entertainment premises, including backrooms, saunas and spas that accommodate sexual encounters, that “gain income from entrance and / or membership fees paid for the use of the premises for sex between the clients but are not premises where sex services take place or are arranged in exchange for payment” (City of Sydney, 2006) such as brothels and escort agencies.

Sex on premises venues are not merely service organisations but businesses operating in the ‘experience economy’ that has emerged as the next step in the ‘progression of economic value’ where customer experiences are distinct from commodities, goods and services (Pine & Gilmore, 1988). The concept of transactional consumption has evolved into a holistic experience of interactions between customer and company, with the customer experience designed to create value for the customer or a source of differentiation as a competitive advantage (Gentile, Spiller & Noci, 2007).

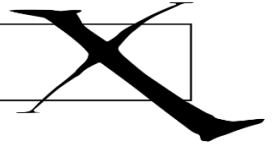
In Sydney, there are five sex on premises venues that cater primarily to gay and bisexual men, Aarows located in the inner west, The Den backroom and Sydney Sauna on Oxford Street, with newcomer Sauna X by 357 nearby in Taylor Square as the latest addition to the industry, following the closures of the previously predominant 357 and Bodyline Spa & Sauna in the past 12 months.

Whether for relaxation, connection or exploration, sex on premises venues are places that provide a safe space for sexual encounters and negotiated consensual acts, with the use of the amenities defining a venue’s signature customer experience included in the price of admission. At Sauna X, these amenities include:

Cafe and Lounge	Mirror room
Bar	Sling room
Secure lockers	Dark room
Spa	Bondage room
Sauna	Glory holes
Steam room	Douching facilities
Showers	Porn cinemas and lounges
Private rooms	Roof top terrace (smoking and vaping allowed)

“When you enter, we’ll give you a locker, a key and a towel ... You go to your locker, change into your towel, have a shower and then the rest is up to you. You can have a spa, a steam, a sauna, or you can go for a wander and explore the cruising areas. If you meet someone, you can have some ‘fun’ in a private room or, if you’d rather, you can do something in a public space like the adult cinema. And if you simply want to relax, you can watch a movie in the lounge, listen to some chill jazz music, have a free coffee, or buy something to eat or drink at the bar.” (McNamara, 2024).

RESEARCH QUESTION & OBJECTIVES



Research question

This research project aims to determine whether again adopting the previously proven 'business as usual' approach to operating the twice failed sex on premises venue, previously occupied by Bodyline Spa & Sauna and now trading as Sauna X by 357, will still satisfy the needs of customers or is the gay community in Sydney wanting more from a sex on premises venue than they did before?

- Who goes to a sex on premises venue and why do they go?
- What criteria is used to choose one venue over another?
- What opportunities exist within the market where expectations have not been met?

Research objectives

Informing the answers to these questions, the research objectives are to:

- Gain a deeper understanding of the reasons why men go to sex on premises venues and their needs being met
- Identify the servicescape factors used by sex on premises venues as points of differentiation in market segmentation
- Discover the relevance of these factors to the customer experience and their influence on preference of venue

BACKGROUND

Without the consent of council or the support of residents, Craig Weedon and Ken Urban (as Teystar Pty Ltd) opened Bodyline Spa and Sauna at 58A Flinders Street on Christmas Eve in 1991, promoted as a 'therapy health and fitness club' for the gay community. But three days later, amidst a backlash from locals, a town planning inspector from the South Sydney City Council issued Bodyline with a notice to cease their unauthorised use of the premises as an illegal brothel. After refusing to comply with the order, the council commenced legal action in the Land and Environment Court of New South Wales to force Bodyline to close, arguing that a jury would have reasonable grounds to find the venue that was facilitating sex on premises as a service an 'outrage to public decency'.

Instead, Justice Stein's judgement (1992) was that "the subject premises are crucial for the establishment and maintenance of the gay community and they fulfil a legitimate social function" and that:

"The sexual acts which occur on the premises are between consenting adult males. Such acts do not constitute criminal offences. They take place in the privacy of the cubicles with locked doors. They are not public exhibitions or performances, but rather consensual private sexual activity. Only homosexual men are likely to resort to the premises. Gay men are very likely to know that sexual acts take place on the premises with the agreement of each party. In the circumstances it may be argued that an outrage to public decency could not be established."

Bodyline had been formally recognised and accepted by civic society (figure 1) but this acceptance was challenged again only a few years later when the business relocated to a new location just around the corner at 10 Taylor Street.

Figure 1

Advertisement with headline from The Sydney Morning Herald

• SAUNA • STEAM ROOM • SPA • CAFE • MEMBERS LOUNGE • MASSAGES • STUDENT CONCESSIONS • BUDDY NIGHTS •

THE SYDNEY MORNING HERALD
JUDGE ALLOWS GAY SEX CLUB

Now it's official

Not only is Bodyline here to stay; but its famous standard of service to the Gay community has been officially recognised in court.

It's a standard of service that we at Bodyline are proud of. And we intend to keep building on it, so we can continue to offer our community its best equipped, friendliest and safest spa and sauna complex.

We are open from 12 noon until 7am Mondays to Thursdays, and continuously from 12 noon Friday until 7am on Monday.

Bodyline is at your service!

Bodyline

58a Flinders St, Darlinghurst
Telephone (02) 360 1006

FREE MARDI GRAS RECOVERY BREAKFAST FROM 5AM

From: *Capital Q: Newspaper for the Queer Capital*, 1992. (<https://doi.org/10.26190/unsworks/21840>)

Pride Holdings Pty Ltd had begun informally operating a sex on premises venue known as Sin for Men at the site (figure 2) but in response to Bodyline's development application, the council "refused consent for the development of the gay sauna on the grounds of noise, unsuitability of the building and that it was not in the public interest of the local residents of Taylor Street" (Prior, 2004).

Figure 2

Advertisement for Sydney's newest backroom



Note: From *Development Application* by Pride Holdings, 1996. (<https://archives.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/nodes/view/1323793>)

Again, Bodyline appealed the decision in the Land and Environment Court and this time, Justice Pearl's judgement (1997) was that:

"An activity such as that proposed should not, as a matter of appropriate planning, be located within a predominantly residential community. Taylor Street is not a pristine, untainted residential area. The majority of the street is occupied as residences, but there is considerable commercial activity at the Flinders end where the site is located. Furthermore, the street is located within the Oxford Street, Flinders Street and South Dowling Street area, which is notable for its venues for entertainment of the gay and lesbian community. A factor which must also be taken in the context of public interest is that the site is intended to provide a safe sex venue. The applicant asserts, and I accept ... that it is committed to disseminating information about the spread of HIV-AIDS and to contributing to public education of the gay community. Looking at it from a planning perspective I see no reason why development consent should be refused in the public interest."

Bodyline had set a new precedent by this recognition for providing an important service to the gay community in Sydney and the sex on premises venue became a popular and profitable business venture until the company went into administration in 2008. Kehoe Pty Ltd, as owner of the site, took over the operations of Bodyline Spa & Sauna until 2015, before leasing the business to Seraja Enterprises who had managerial control up until 2018 (figure 3).

In mid-2019, the premises were leased to PJBL Pty Ltd and were rebranded Bodyline Sydney (figure 4) but under new management and in the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic, Bodyline closed its doors eighteen months later, telling the gay community on social media “they can go fuck themselves” (Harrigan, 2021).

Figure 3

Bodyline Spa & Sauna logo 1991 – 2018



Note: Copyright Kehoe Pty Ltd 1997.

Figure 4

Bodyline Sydney logo 2019 - 2021



Note: Copyright PJBL Pty Ltd 2019.

It is this expression of the former management's attitude toward its customers, that is similarly reflected in an apparent disregard given to hygiene and the upkeep of the venue's amenities, that is thought to have caused the demise of Sydney's premiere sex on premises venue and most popular bath house. Because while Bodyline dived, the competition thrived, as alternative places for the gay community to meet and socialise, throwing parties and hosting ticketed events at a time when the formerly frequented bars and clubs on Oxford Street could only open under lockdown with reduced capacities, if allowed to open at all.

Fast forward a few years and as the city emerged from its coronavirus slumber, Kehoe Pty Ltd in a new partnership with the Blackberry Group Pty Ltd that was managing the adjacent ARQ nightclub, formed Zito No 1 Pty Ltd and renovated Bodyline Spa & Sauna. Refreshing the brand (figure 5), the sex on premises venue reopened to the public in October 2023. However, by adopting the same 'business as usual' approach in its management and refusing to invest in any additional marketing nor consider how the world has changed since the venue's controversial beginnings more than thirty years ago, the latest reincarnation of Bodyline Spa & Sauna "struggled to regain its former glory" (Dovans & Frappell, 2024). With declining revenue as a result of poor attendance, the sex on premises venue ceased trading yet again and closed less than six months later albeit for the final time.

Around the same time, another sex on premises venue, 357, was being forced to close due to development of the site they had been leasing in the CBD for more than twenty years. The manager of 357, as McLuu Pty Ltd, under terms of strict confidentiality, swiftly negotiated and acquired the site previously occupied by Bodyline, rebranding it as Sauna X by 357 (figure 6) and reopened the sex on premises venue on 15 April 2024, “promising the same staff, parties and welcoming atmosphere that defined the original venue” (James, 2024) with some immediate enhancements and other planned changes to follow in the weeks and months to come.

Figure 5

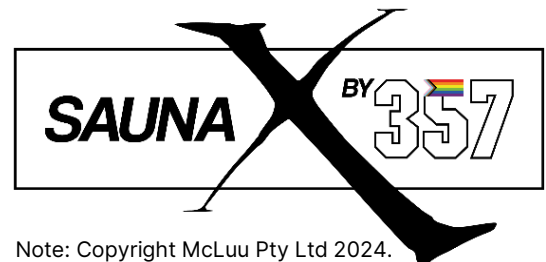
Bodyline Spa & Sauna logo 2023 – 2024



Note: Copyright Blackberry Group Pty Ltd 2022.

Figure 6

Sauna X by 357 logo 2024



Note: Copyright McLuu Pty Ltd 2024.

While Sauna X may have been “purposefully created as a safe haven for men who engage in consensual contact and connection with other men” (Sauna X, 2024), unlike Bodyline which catered exclusively to gay and bisexual men, Sauna X now welcomes transgender men, along with straight men and women on Tuesdays, designating it ‘Ladies Day’ and grants both cis women and transgender women free entry to the sex on premises venue, regardless of their sexuality. “Heterosexual men have to be 100 per cent comfortable in their own sexuality to be around gay and bisexual men, who, quite frankly, will probably try to pick them up” (McNamara, 2024) otherwise “this is not the venue for them” (McNamara).

On Friday nights, blackout parties are thrown for anonymous encounters in the dark and Saturdays are now towel free, with staff enforcing nudity as a precondition for admission. The steam room has been renovated since opening and the construction of a bar has commenced, as the sex on premises venue has recently been approved for an on-premises liquor licence by NSW Liquor & Gaming. Two submissions were made to council in support of the application, however two submissions from unnamed parties were also received objecting to the application, citing concerns about the trading hours and the lack of management intervention in disturbances to the neighbourhood caused by intoxicated customers. Yet, thanks to the AIDS Council of NSW (ACON) describing the sex on premises venue as a safe environment, with the police and council raising no other concerns, Sauna X will soon serve alcohol from a bar in the venue’s lounge (Grubb, 2024).

SITUATIONAL ANALYSIS



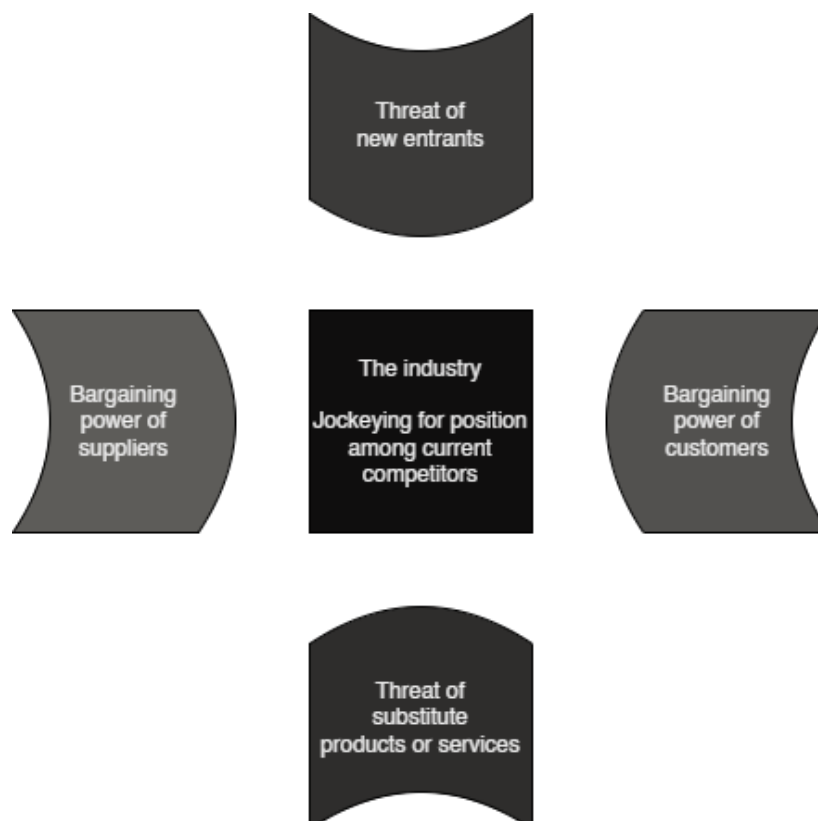
To understand the business of selling sex as a service in Sydney, including the factors that influence consumer behaviour and the forces that impact service delivery, an analysis of the competitive landscape in which sex on premises venues operate was performed in order to understand the current environment for Sauna X by 357, using conceptual frameworks to identify potential opportunities and threats, and to gain insights into the market conditions and competitive landscape, to in turn better inform the research recommendations.

Porter's Five Forces

Introduced in 1979, Porter's five forces (figure 7) is a model "used to identify and analyse an industry's competitive forces" (Porter, 1979) and remains "a fundamental tool for strategic analysts plotting the competitive landscape of an industry" (Porter). In his model, Porter sets out the five forces at play in any given industry, being the current competition, the potential for new entrants, the negotiating power of suppliers, the bargaining power of customers and the ability of customers to find substitutes, to guide a business in "determining the intensity of competition and potential profitability within their market, helping them better understand where power lies in their sector" (Gratton, 2024).

Figure 7

Porter's five forces



Note: Adapted from *Forces governing competition in an industry* by M.E. Porter, 1979.

Threat of new entrants

An industry where new businesses can enter easily usually results in lower profit margins and market share. The barriers to entry for a new sex on premises venue in Sydney are relatively low, if considering only the basic requirements of a suitable place with necessary amenities. While the initial setup costs may not be prohibitive, the regulations and requirements needed to obtain development approval, particularly with regards to ensuring privacy and security, are an additional barrier to new entrants. That, along with the established reputation of existing venues who benefit from existing brand loyalty, the threat of new entrants can be considered as moderate.

Bargaining power of suppliers

Suppliers for sex on premises venues include cleaning contractors and hospitality vendors who hold little power, as a venue can easily switch providers if the costs become too high or the service quality unsatisfactory. While some specialised products and services for maintaining hygiene, privacy and security may be necessary, such items are widely available and easily sourced, keeping the bargaining power of suppliers relatively low.

Bargaining power of customers

Customers have many adult entertainment options available to them, both in the physical and online worlds, exerting pressure on sex on premises venues to offer better services at lower prices. If a sex on premises venue fails to meet its customers' expectations, those customers can quickly switch to another option with relative ease, making the bargaining power of customers quite high. A sex on premises venue must provide the features and benefits sought by its customers, to command loyalty and reduce their bargaining power, else failing to deliver on their expectations will only increase the likelihood of customer churn and turnover.

Threat of substitute products or services

Many substitute adult activities are available to customers, including bars and nightclubs, online dating apps, as well as all manner of private and public functions and events, that offer differing degrees of social and sexual environments that cater to customers. This presents a major threat to sex on premises venues and the ever-increasing number of alternatives on offer will undoubtedly continue to magnify this threat and impact the attendance of sex on premises venues.

Current competitors

The more competitors in an industry, the fiercer the rivalry and the rivalry in Sydney from other sex on premises venues directly competing is high, although it has significantly decreased since two of the predominant venues ceased trading in the previous year. Price wars, promotional efforts, facility upgrades, themed events and trading hours are a few of the methods used to make the competition intense, contributing to the rivalry among the remaining venues to gain an advantage in the current competitive landscape. While such tactics may stimulate venues to provide better services, they can also erode profitability and market stability over time.

PEST Analysis

In 1967, Francis Aguilar developed a framework for “scanning the business environment” (Aguilar, 1967) and evaluating the external macro-environmental factors that are the major influences on the business environment. At its core, PEST is “the belief that a comprehensive assessment of the major areas of influence that affect the sector in which an organisation is positioned, as well as the organisation itself, can facilitate more effective strategic planning” (Kenton, 2024). A PEST analysis (figure 8) includes four components that are used to evaluate the political, economic, social and technological factors that may impact the viability and profitability of a business, to offer some insight into the potential strategies for navigating the challenges and leveraging the opportunities highlighted (figure X).

Figure 8

PEST analysis



Note: Adapted from *PEST Analysis* by V. Jaiani. (<https://www.sixsigmatrainingfree.com/pest-analysis.html>)

Political

The political factors measure the degree of political stability and government intervention in the economy. Sex on premises venues may choose to voluntarily comply with ACON's Play Zone: Sex on Premises Venue Code of Practice, however they must meet the conditions of consent imposed by the City of Sydney in the approval of a site's development application and comply with the council's Sex Industry and Adult Entertainment Premises Development Guidelines, along with other local regulations including those regarding general waste management within the Policy for Waste Minimisation in New Developments and the ongoing measurement of water temperature that is recorded for the Regulated Systems (Legionella) Register. State government techniques and recommendations regarding venue cleanliness and hygiene, as outlined within NSW Communicable Diseases' Health and Safety Guidelines for Sex on Premises Venues must be practised, as well as ensuring that the cleaning of a spa pool complies with NSW Health's Public Swimming Pool and Spa Pool Guidelines and is chlorinated according to their Protocol for Minimising Risk of Cryptosporidium Contamination in Public Swimming Pools and Spa Pools. A venue must also have an adequate number of staff trained in first aid as per NSW WorkCover's First Aid in the Workplace Code of Practice. A sex on premises venue's douching facilities must comply with the Australian Standard 3500 Plumbing and Drainage, the washing of towels with the Australian Standard 4146 Laundry Practice and the disposal of sharps with the Australian Standard 4031 Non-reusable Containers for the Collection of Sharp Medical Items used in Health Care Areas (Blackberry Group, 2023).

Economic

The economic factors of the day can have a great impact on a business and its future growth. Due its location, the rent for Sauna X is considerably high, however having a favourable local labour market makes it easy to recruit unskilled casual staff with low wage requirements. Maintaining high hygiene standards in accordance with public health regulations does increase operational costs, and the energy costs in terms of heating the venue and its amenities are only likely to rise in coming years. While tourism, particularly around the Sydney Gay and Lesbian Mardi Gras, will be of benefit to sex on premises venues, the current cost of living crisis and the resulting drop in disposable income will impact customer spending on leisure, reducing attendance and customers' frequency of visits to Sauna X.

Social

Thanks to the increasing social acceptance of the GLBTQ community, particularly over recent years, as well as medical advances in the prevention and treatment of HIV, the stigma and prejudice that once deterred customers from a sex on premises venue are no longer the case. Sauna X may now be seen as offering the community a place for social engagement, along with safe sex, that can foster community acceptance and customer loyalty. However social and demographic shifts, such as the trend toward virtual connections through the increased use of online dating apps like Grindr, means

that the demand for physical meeting places like sex on premises venues has decreased, especially among younger men.

Technological

The need for customer privacy is crucial in a sex on premises venue and the use of CCTV, discreet check in systems and private payment options all help to build trust with customers concerned about their anonymity. While the rise of dating apps may have decreased the demand for sex on premises venues, the physical in-person experience is significantly different to any virtual alternatives. Communicating these benefits to customers is best delivered through online and digital marketing, which generally has less restrictions on the advertising of adult products and services than the mainstream media, and can be specifically targeted to a particular audience while still maintaining an individual customer’s necessary discretion.

SWOT Analysis

A SWOT analysis (figure 9) is a strategic planning technique that is used for a business to identify the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats that may lead to fresh perspectives and new ideas, through the assessment of internal and external factors, as well as current and future potential. The technique is intended to “guide businesses toward strategies more likely to be successful, and away from those in which they have been, or are likely to be, less successful” (Kenton, 2024).

Figure 9
SWOT analysis



Note: Adapted from *How to do a SWOT analysis* by A. Lindley, 2023. (<https://www.semrush.com/blog/swot-analysis-examples/>)

Strengths

Strengths describe what a business excels at and what separates it from the competition. Providing a service exclusively to gay men, Sauna X caters to a niche market with a clear demand. Through its connection to the previously popular but now closed 357, Sauna X brings that venue's brand loyalty to its new location, with satisfied returning customers and positive word of mouth. The supplementary products available through the venue's café and licensed bar provide an additional revenue stream beyond the price of admission.

Weaknesses

Weaknesses are what stops a business from performing at its optimum level and are areas that need improvement to remain competitive. Catering primarily to gay and bisexual men, Sauna X's market reach is limited, along with its potential for growth. Social stigma and public perception, while reduced in comparison to previous years, still discourages some potential customers that insist on discretion, meaning homophobia still presents a challenge that can hinder any advertising and marketing attempts to attract new customers. Compliance with public health, hygiene and safety standards, at local, state and federal levels, remain difficult and can be costly to administer.

Opportunities

Any favourable external factors that can give a business a competitive advantage are considered opportunities. The increasing social acceptance and visibility of GLBTQ spaces, including sex on premises venues, allows for some potential expansion of Sauna X's customer base through co-hosted events, themed nights and promoted parties. Through targeted social media, online advertising and integration with appropriate dating apps, as well as partnerships with community organisations and other entertainment providers, the venue's reputation can be enhanced to attract new customers, while simultaneously driving up customer loyalty and engagement in existing customers.

Threats

While the proliferation of dating apps providing alternatives for connection have already reduced the demand for sex on premises venues to some degree, the cost-of-living crisis and other such economic downturns that reduce disposable income, also contribute to lower attendance and a reduction in revenue. In light of the COVID-19 pandemic, another communicable disease outbreak, such as M-POX, will likely have a significant impact on Sauna X's operations. Similarly, any negative media coverage or social backlash will also impact the public's perception of risk and affect a customer's willingness to visit the sex on premises venue.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Originating in accountancy, philosophy and systems theory, a conceptual framework “draws upon existing theories, models, or established bodies of knowledge to provide a structure for understanding the research problem” (Singh, 2023) and the cause-and-effect relationships between identified factors and forces, as either dependent or independent variables for measurement.

Experiential Hierarchy of Effects

The experiential hierarchy of effects theory created by Lavidge & Steiner in 1961 (figure 10) is a model of consumer behaviour used in advertising to explain how consumer attitudes based on hedonic consumption are formed and the role that emotions and experiences play in shaping behaviour and beliefs about a product or service. It suggests that how consumers think (cognition), along with their preferences and the choices they make, is the result of their feelings and emotions (affect) coupled with their experiences (behaviour), rather than a cognitive evaluation that informs their attitude.

Figure 10

Experiential hierarchy of effects



Note: Adapted from *Attitudes* by V. Noguti, 2020. (<https://canvas.uts.edu.au/courses/19659/files/1642709/>)

Affect

Applying the model to a sex on premises venue, customers engage through their ‘feelings first’ and an emotional response, likely driven by a desire for connection, self-expression, sexual exploration or a need for belonging and acceptance. The venue’s ambiance, including lighting, music and general atmosphere, plays a significant role in creating an immediate emotional response, with a warm and welcoming environment triggering excitement, curiosity and a sense of comfort and ease. The venue provides a haven for customers to emotionally and sexually connect with others who share a similar identity and interest, fostering an emotional sense of belonging, acceptance and understanding, while still maintaining a suitable degree of privacy and discretion.

Behaviour

After the initial emotional engagement, a customer’s behaviour tends to act in accordance with their feelings. They may decide to explore the venue, communicate and engage with others or participate in

sexual activities, based upon the emotions fostered by the venue's environmental cues that drive the desire to continue or enhance the positive emotional experience the customer seeks. The experiential social and physical environment encourages exploration and expression, facilitating engagement by customers acting on impulse, without any complex decision making or involvement.

Cognition

With these experiences, customers then form beliefs and attitudes about the sex on premises venue and about themselves in relation to it, reinforcing their own identity or the acceptance of their sexuality, in turn creating a favourable attitude toward the sex on premises venue itself. A positive experience may lead to a customer returning to the venue again in future and repeated positive experiences can strengthen a customer's loyalty, recommending the venue to others as they share their experiences with personal endorsements.

Functional Attitude Theory

The functional theory of attitudes (figure 11) takes this understanding a step further, suggesting that "at the psychological level, the reasons for holding or for changing attitudes are found in the functions they perform for the individual, specifically the functions of adjustment, ego defense, value expression and knowledge" (Katz, 1960). The framework helps to explain our pursuit of rewards and avoidance of punishments (utilitarian function) to obtain particular benefits, the way we use past experience (knowledge function) to simplify our decision making toward more desirable outcomes, the positive expression of our values and beliefs to others (value-expressive function) and the attitudes we form as a defense mechanism (ego-defensive function) to avoid any negative effects that might harm our precious ego.

Figure 11

Functional theory of attitudes



Note: Adapted from *The functional approach to the study of attitudes* by D. Katz, 1960. (<https://doi.org/10.1086/266945>)

Utilitarian function

The utilitarian function relates to seeking pleasure through rewards and avoiding discomfort from punishments. At a sex on premises venue, this function might be fulfilled by the excitement, enjoyment and pleasure that the sex on premises venue provides. By offering an immediate and tangible benefit, such as social interaction, sexual gratification or simply the excitement of being in a sexually affirming open space, a customer will feel positive about the venue because it fulfills their need to connect with others sharing a similar interest or desire and provides comfort and satisfaction in an environment where they feel like they belong.

Ego-defensive function

The ego-defensive function involves the attitudes protecting our self-esteem from external threats or defending against our internal conflicts and feelings. For some men, their attitude towards sex on premises venues helps mitigate their feelings of shame or the stigma relating to their sexuality. Embracing their attitude, they can reinforce their own self-acceptance or reduce any negative feelings held regarding their own insecurities or societal judgement. Others may hold an attitude that serves as a way to cope with internalised homophobia or pressure from their peers. It acts as a defensive psychological buffer against the discomfort they may feel regarding their sexuality and desires.

Value-expressive function

The value-expressive function relates to the attitudes that allow the expression of our individual values and beliefs, known also as our self-concept. Attitudes about sex on premises venues might reflect broader community values surrounding sexuality and pride in identity, as spaces for the open expression of these values without fear of judgment, with any alignment to our personal values only serving to reinforce the positive attitudes held.

Knowledge function

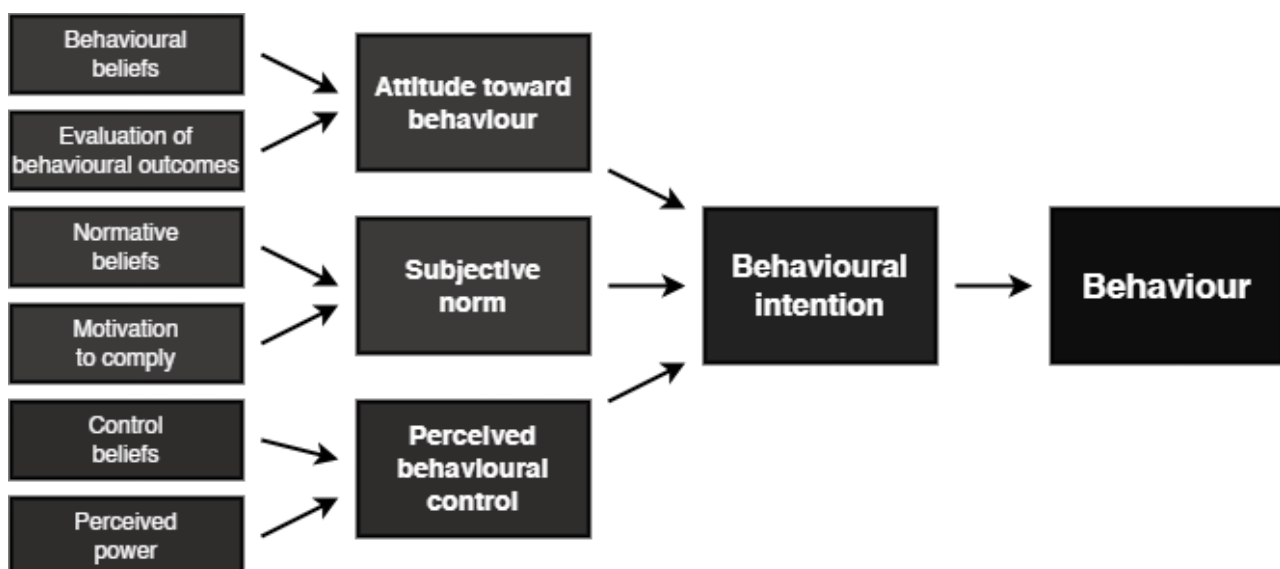
The knowledge function is that which helps in making sense of the world around us, organising our understanding of places and faces with structure and meaning. A sex on premises venue is a safe space to explore and experiment with sexuality and identity, in a consistent and somewhat reliable way that is intended to feel natural and normal, free from any complexity or misunderstanding present in other environments, to inform individual knowledge through self-discovery and mutual participation.

Theories of Reasoned Action and Planned Behaviour

The theory of reasoned action is a cognitive theory and mathematical model first proposed by psychologists Martin Fishbein and Icek Ajzen in 1967 to predict behavioural intentions as a function of attitudes and subjective norms. Adding perceived behavioural control as a component to improve the predictive power of the theory, Azjen proposed the theory of planned behaviour in 1985. Together (figure 12), “they believed that attitude, subjective norms, and perceived behaviour control all contribute to intention, which leads to some extent to behaviour” (Nickerson, 2023) albeit imperfectly. Although “as a general rule, the stronger the intention to engage in a behaviour, the more likely should be its performance” (Ajzen, 1991).

Figure 12

Theories of reasoned action and planned behaviour



Note: Adapted from *Understanding attitudes and predicting social behavior* by M. Fishbein & I. Ajzen, 1980.

Attitude toward behaviour

An attitude toward behaviour is our overall positive or negative evaluation of a particular behaviour, good or bad, right or wrong, and whether we believe the behaviour will lead to an outcome we value. Attitudes toward the behaviours relating to sex on premises venues would include personal feelings around the excitement, pleasure and gratification associated with the concept of sex as a service.

Subjective norm

The perceived peer pressures and social influences that shape expectations, whether to engage in a particular behaviour, perceived with either approval or sensing disapproval, are the internal conflicts and subjective norm that influence our intentions.

Perceived behavioural control

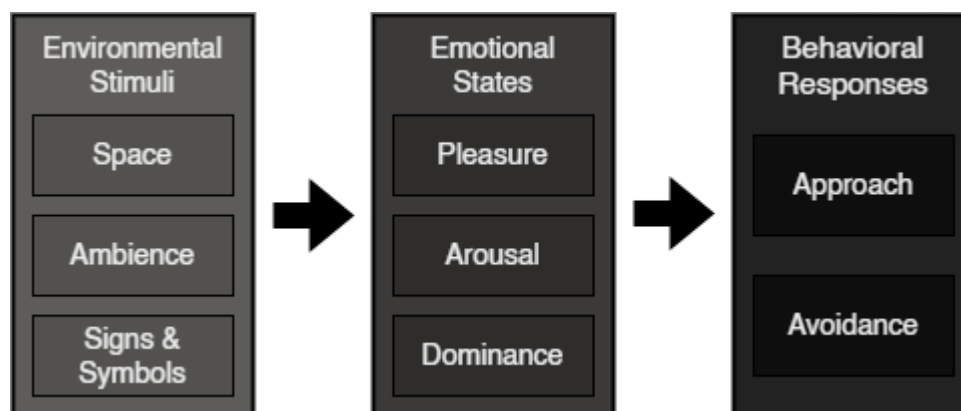
The perceived ease or difficulty of engaging in the behaviour, including any concerns regarding accessibility, privacy and security, financial and time constraints, or even internal factors around a customer's confidence in their own identity and sexuality, determines how likely the customer's behaviour acts on their intentions.

Mehrabian-Russell Model of Environmental Influence

The central idea within the theoretical framework of environmental psychology developed by Albert Mehrabian and James Russell in 1974 (figure 13) is that environmental stimuli within physical environments influences our emotional states and subsequent behavioural responses. The model uses three dimensions of pleasure, arousal and dominance, as the basis for describing and measuring emotional states, that shaped by environmental factors, lead to an approach or avoidance behavioural response.

Figure 13

Mehrabian-Russell model of environmental influence



Note: Adapted from *A basic environmental psychology model* by F. Clifford, 2023. (<https://wearesimplybetter.com/knowledge-hub/power-of-environments/>)

Environmental stimuli

The physical aspects of a sex on premises venue, including the layout of the space, décor, lighting, sound, temperature and overall ambience, as well as any signs and symbols, act as environmental stimuli that evoke emotional responses in customers and are critical in shaping how customers feel inside the venue. Dim lighting and background music in warm private spaces contribute to a customer's sense of intimacy, while friendly and non-judgemental staff employed in a casual setting, along with a clean environment, help customers feel at ease and encourages engagement. The presence of certain cues such as soft furnishings that make the environment more comfortable or instructional signage

that make the amenities less intimidating, enhance the feelings that contribute to the overall satisfaction of customers.

Emotional states

Pleasure is the emotional state that reflects the enjoyment felt by a customer. Within a sex on premises venue, this pleasure might be experienced through the engaging ambience of a warm and welcoming environment that allows customers to freely express themselves or it might be felt through a sense of connection by means of the interactions with others that makes customers more likely to stay longer and return in future. The emotional state of arousal reflects the stimulation and excitement felt by a customer. Stimulating visual, auditory and social cues, including mood lighting and energetic music, along with specific design features within the sex on premises venue to encourage curiosity and facilitate exploration such as mirrors and mazes, contribute to the atmosphere and elevate customer arousal. Dominance is the emotional state of control over a customer's surroundings and is enhanced by providing customers with options, such as lockable doors to private rooms and dimmer switches that can change the luminance of the lighting within. When customers feel empowered and in control of their own experiences, any anxieties about being in a sex on premises venue decrease and their potential enjoyment increases.

Behavioural responses

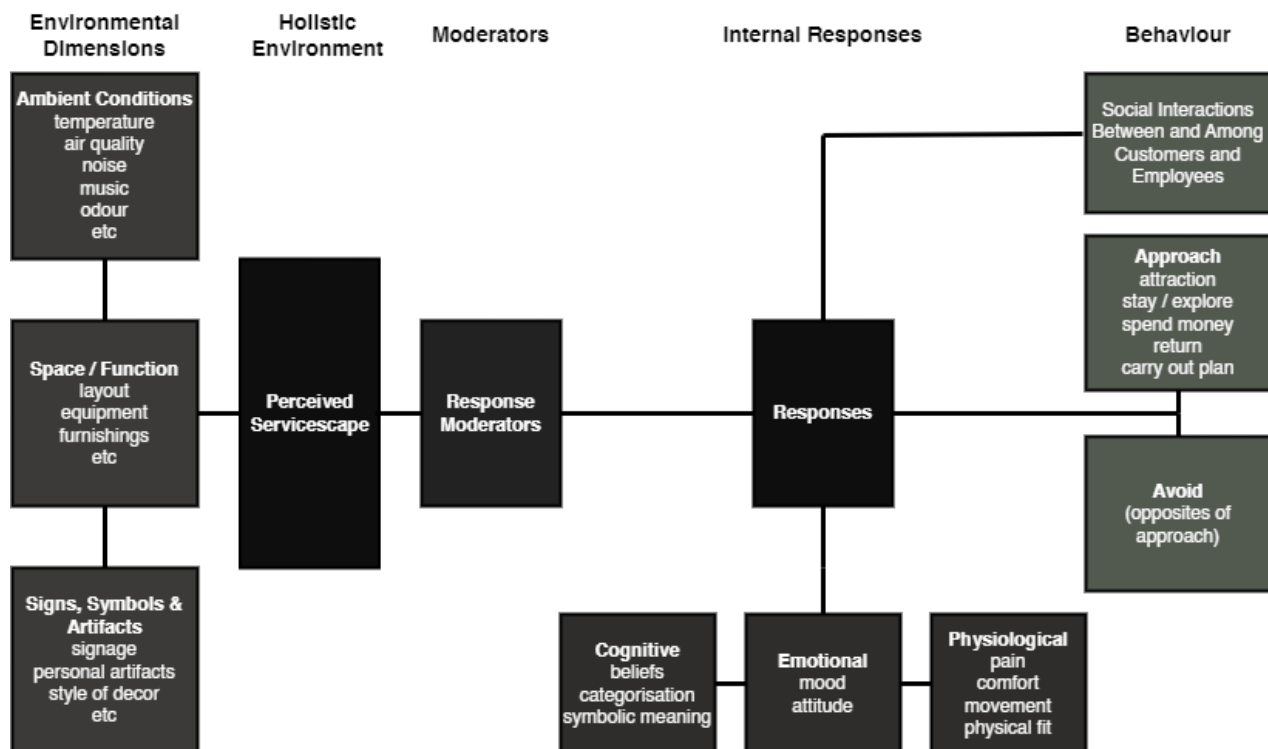
Based on the emotional states of pleasure, arousal and dominance felt in response to the environmental stimuli of a sex on premises venue, customers will choose either an approach behaviour to stay, explore and engage with the sex on premises experience, or conversely an avoidance behaviour to avoid certain areas or that compels a customer to leave the venue entirely.

Servicescape

The servicescape (figure 14) was proposed by Mary Jo Bitner, an assistant professor in marketing, as a framework based upon environmental psychology that "draws together relevant literature in marketing, organisational behaviour, human factors / ergonomics and architecture" (Bitner, 1992) to explain how "internal responses to the environment influence the behaviour of individual customers" (Bitner) and explores the "ability of the physical surroundings to facilitate achievement of organisational as well as marketing goals" (Bitner).

Figure 14

Conceptual framework for the environment-customer relationship within the servicescape



Note: Adapted from *Framework for Understanding Environment-User Relationships in Service Organizations* by M.J. Bitner, 1992. (<https://doi.org/10.2307/1252042>)

Environmental dimensions

Dim lighting and controlled temperature are conditions that contribute to the atmosphere in a sex on premises venue to enhance comfort, combined with background music to align with a venue's intended vibe, whether it be it sensual and relaxed or more lively. To guide and facilitate the interactions of customers, the arrangement of the venue's space for these activities is designed to allow customers to choose the settings suited to the types of sexual interactions they desire. Signs remind customers about safe practices and essential etiquette while other visual cues such as the décor, furniture and the equipment provided for use can help orient customers and set expected behavioural norms.

Holistic environment

How customers interact with and experience the physical and sensory environment within a sex on premises venue is the perceived servicescape that contributes to a customer's feelings of comfort, safety, privacy, acceptance, belonging, confidence, arousal, intimacy and freedom in self-expression.

Moderators

The internal and external factors that influence how customers react to the perceived servicescape are the moderators that shape their emotional, social and behavioural responses to engaging with the environment and interacting with others. A customer's individual comfort levels, psychological needs for anonymity and privacy, desires for inclusivity and social connection, personal boundaries and perceptions of safety and hygiene, as well as social norms and behavioural expectations, are some of the response moderators that can impact customers' reactions and behaviours in a sex on premises venue.

Internal responses

Emotional responses to the ambience of a sex on premises venue can relax, excite or even empower customers. Physiological reactions to the servicescape can heighten awareness, decrease anxiety and evoke intimacy, in a safe space that promotes acceptance of individual sexuality and encourages self-expression. Cognitive reaction and interpretation of the social norms and behavioural expectations from the environment in a sex on premises venue helps to facilitate the spaces for sexual interactions to occur with mutual respect.

Behaviour

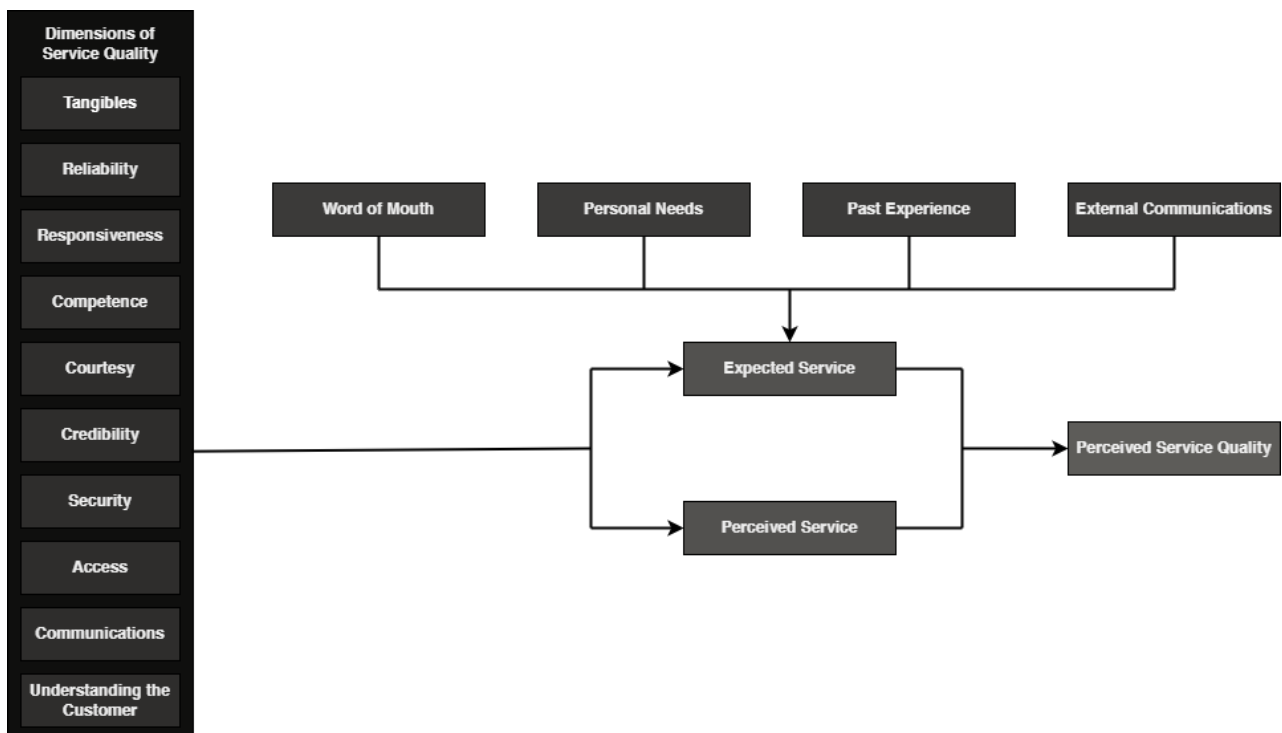
The approach or avoidance behaviours of customers in sex on premises venues are indicated by their actions, to engage with the amenities and interact with other customers. Their openness to communication, social interaction, self-expression and sexual exploration, as well as their adoption of expected etiquette, adaption of behavioural norms and their demonstrated respect for boundaries, is all shaped by a venue's design and layout, ambience and atmosphere, sensory elements, inclusivity cues and safety signals.

Gaps Model of Service Quality

Customer satisfaction is one of the most basic concepts in marketing and refers to "the consumer's fulfilment response. It is a judgement that a product or service feature, or the product or service itself, provides a pleasurable level of consumption-related fulfilment." (Oliver, 1997). Service quality is another critical element of customer perception but distinctly different from customer satisfaction in that it is an "attitude formed by a long-term, overall evaluation of a firm's performance" (Hoffman & Bateson, 2017) and is the difference between a customer's expectation of service performance and the perceived service they receive, driven by service quality dimensions that influence their perception (figure 15).

Figure 15

Customer assessment of service quality



Note: Adapted from *Delivering Quality Service: Balancing Customer Perceptions and Expectations* by V.A. Zeithaml et al. 1990.

The gaps model of service quality (figure 16) is a conceptual framework that expands upon the service quality concept, including the causes for any possible shortfalls in service quality, referred to as 'provider gaps' that must be closed first in order to close any 'customer gap', which is the most critical to the delivery of service quality.

There are four provider gaps plus the customer gap:

The listening gap: between customer expectations and management perceptions

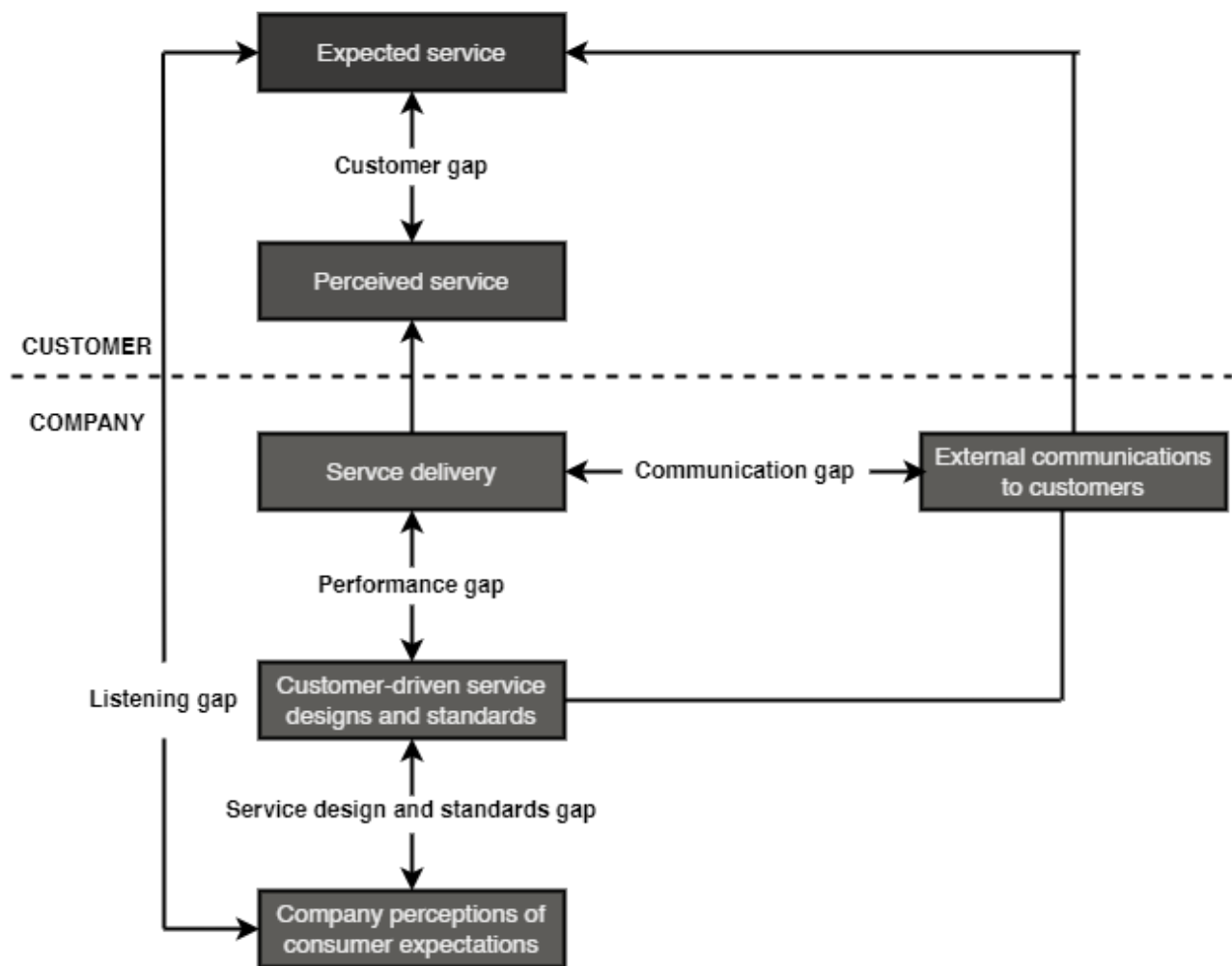
The service design and standards gap: for the wrong service quality standards

The service performance gap

The communication gap: when promises do not match delivery

Figure 16

The gaps model of service quality



Note: Adapted from *Technology's impact on the gaps model of service quality* by M.J. Bitner et al. 2010.

By gathering customers' opinions about their perception of the service quality of sex on premises venues and their use of the included amenities, then analysing their responses with regards to the particular gap types and subsequent gap factors within the gaps model of service quality framework, any immediate issues requiring further investigation can be identified and in turn, any systemic failures that are found can be suitably addressed through the implementation of an appropriately planned strategy to close the specific 'gaps'.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY



This research project adopts a mixed-methods approach, integrating both qualitative and quantitative data to achieve a comprehensive understanding of the research problem. Utilising both primary and secondary data sources with different types of data enhances the validity of the findings.

Qualitative Data

Informal interviews were conducted with three former Bodyline Spa & Sauna employees to gain insights into the issues faced by the businesses in which they worked, being insights beyond those to emerge from the quantitative data collected from customers.

A focus group was then conducted with five regular customers of sex on premises venues to aid the questionnaire design, by determining the likely summary responses from a survey of customers of sex on premises venues.

Quantitative Data

A structured questionnaire (appendix 1) was designed to collect primary data from the target population with a sample size of 15 respondents, asking 15 questions to quantify customers' preferences, perceptions and opinions of sex on premises venues, primarily through scaled response options that reflect the degree to which respondents agree or disagree with common factors or constructs.

Secondary Data

Secondary data sourced from the annual Gay Community Periodic Survey, conducted by the Centre for Social Research in Health in conjunction with UNSW, is used to more accurately understand the behaviours of gay men, through the analysis of the survey results gained from a larger sample size.

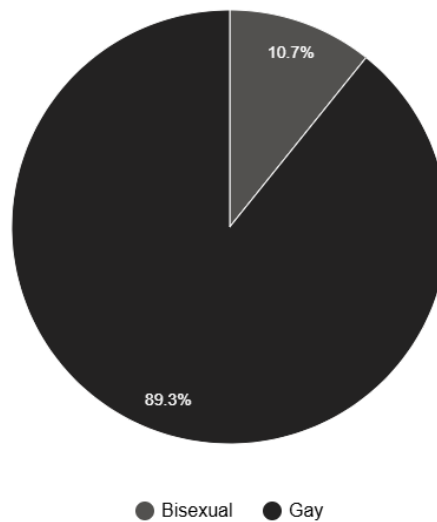
Other secondary data including social media posts and online customer reviews have also been observed, in order to evaluate the extent of the venue's current marketing measures, and to identify any issues in service delivery that need to be addressed with service recovery.

RESEARCH FINDINGS & RESULTS

The results of the most recent Gay Community Periodic Survey conducted in 2023 show that most men within the sample identify as gay (84%) rather than bisexual (10%) (figure 17) and nearly all within the sample identify their gender as cisgender (95%) as opposed to transgender (1%) or non-binary (3%) (figure 18).

Figure 17

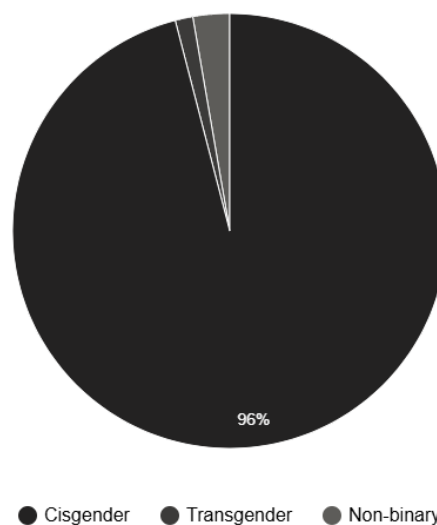
Sexuality



Note: Adapted from *Demographics* by T. Broady et al. 2023. (<http://dx.doi.org/10.26190/g48d-zh77>)

Figure 18

Gender

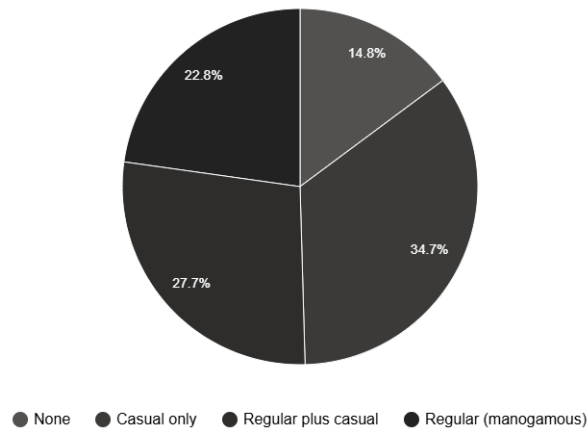


Note: Adapted from *Demographics* by T. Broady et al. 2023. (<http://dx.doi.org/10.26190/g48d-zh77>)

While a small number of men (15%) have not had a single sexual partner in the six months prior to the survey, only 23% of respondents were in a monogamous relationship, with most men (62%) having casual sex or regular sex with more than one partner (figure 19).

Figure 19

Current relationship status

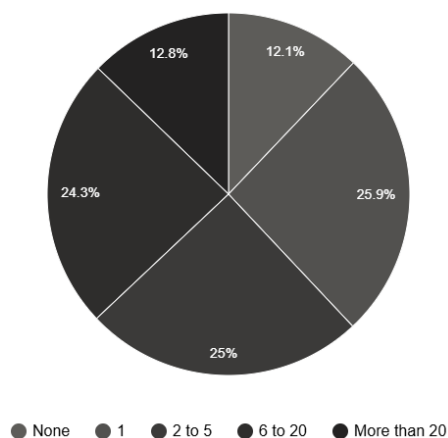


Note: Adapted from *Current relationships with men* by T. Broady et al. 2023. (<http://dx.doi.org/10.26190/g48d-zh77>)

The number of men having had no sexual partner in the six months prior to the survey was around 1 in 10 (12%), with a similar number (13%) reporting that they had more than 20 different sexual partners (figure 20). Around a quarter of the respondents have had just one sexual partner (26%) but the overwhelming majority (62%) have had many.

Figure 20

Number of sexual partners

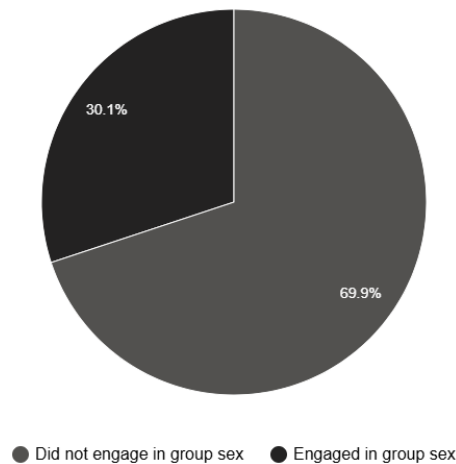


Note: Adapted from *Number of different male sex partners in the six months prior to the survey, by HIV status of participants* by T. Broady et al. 2023. (<http://dx.doi.org/10.26190/g48d-zh77>)

While most men (70%) have not engaged in group sex, a significant number of respondents (30%) said they had participated in group sex in the six months prior to the survey (figure 21).

Figure 21

Engaging in group sex

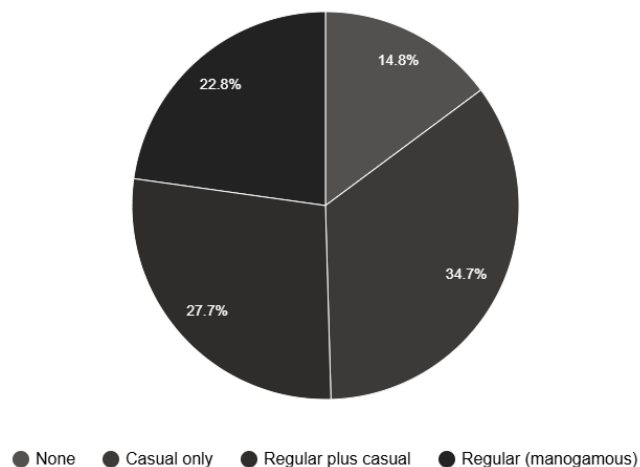


Note: Adapted from *Drug use for sex and group sex in the six months prior to the survey* by T. Broady et al. 2023. (<http://dx.doi.org/10.26190/g48d-zh77>)

The findings of the annual survey also show that gay men continue to meet their sexual partners through all manner of activities (figure 22), primarily connecting online through apps such as Grindr (81%) yet many men (31%) meet at sex on premises venues.

Figure 22

Where men meet their sex partners

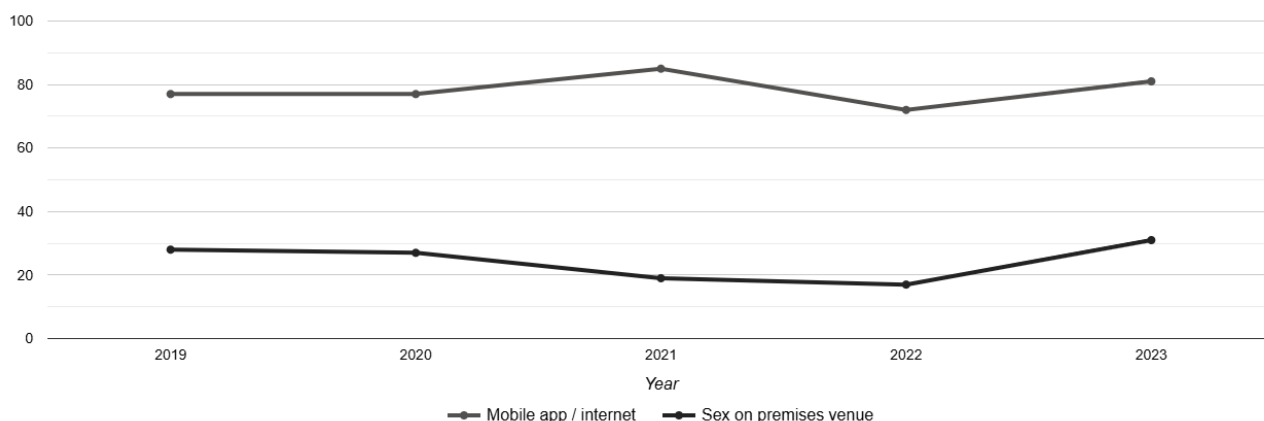


Note: Adapted from *Where participants met their male sex partners in the six months prior to the survey* by T. Broady et al. 2023. (<http://dx.doi.org/10.26190/g48d-zh77>)

Even after accounting for the impact of COVID-19 lockdown restrictions, these statistics have not changed much over time (figure 23) however it should be noted that more men have met their sexual partners at sex on premises venues last year than in any of the past five years.

Figure 23

Where men met their sex partners historically



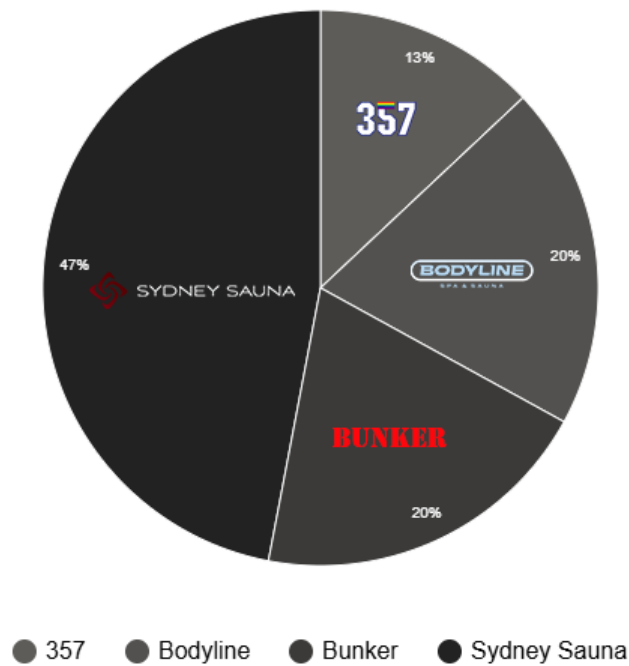
Note: Adapted from *Where participants met their male sex partners in the six months prior to the survey* by T. Broady et al. 2023. (<http://dx.doi.org/10.26190/g48d-zh77>)

Analysis of this secondary data suggests that the demand for sex on premises venues still exists in Sydney, and if anything, the demand has increased. Similarly, it can be argued that as most men have had casual or regular sex with multiple partners, with around a third engaging in group sex, the need for sex on premises venues as spaces to facilitate these encounters is also supported by these findings. However, if Bodyline Sydney's closure during the pandemic was due to a reduction in attendance, the difference between the sex on premises venue being financially viable or not is slim, with attendance levels dropping by only 30% during the pandemic compared to the year prior. Similarly, the decision made by Sauna X to designate an entire day as Ladies Day must also be questioned, as the results suggest that this initiative will only extend the potential customer reach by 1% yet the decision to diversify and open the venue to all genders and sexualities may prove to be a deterrent to attendance for the majority of men who identify simply as cisgender gay or cisgender bisexual.

Not all sex is the same and the degree of deviance practised by gay men in Sydney is reflected in the primary data collected about the sex on premises venue they attend most often (figure 24).

Figure 24

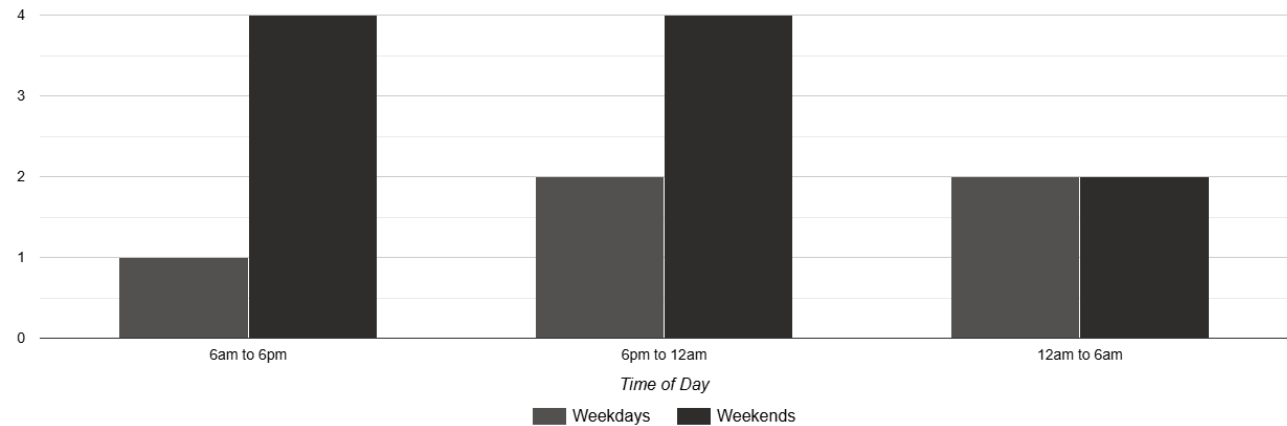
Sex on premises venues most often visited



Sex on premises venues are required by law, as a condition of their development consent by council, to close each day for at least four hours for mandatory cleaning but can remain open 24 hours on weekends and this is when venues are most popular and understandably, also their busiest (figure 25).

Figure 25

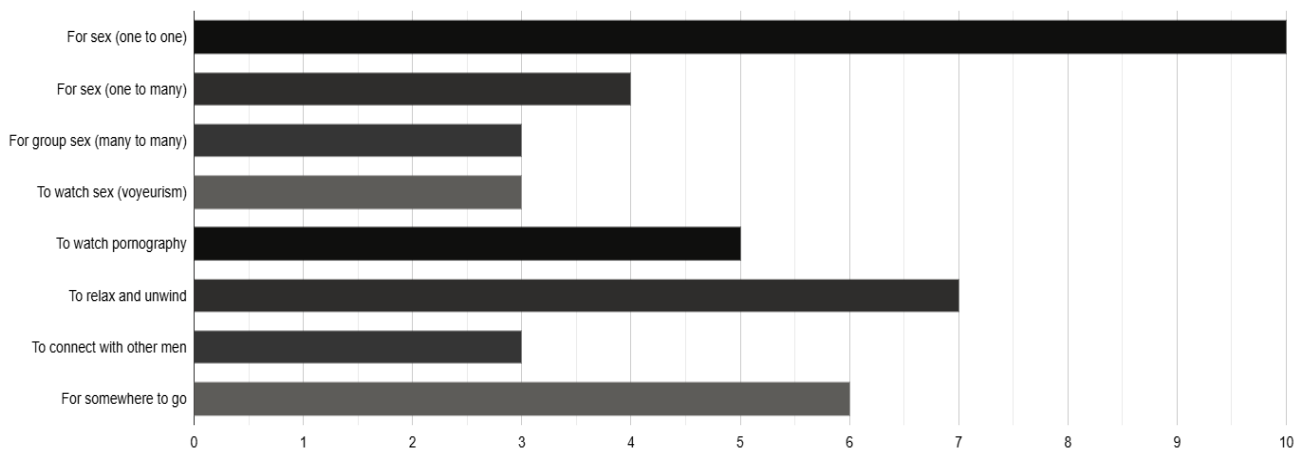
Time sex on premises venues most often visited



While it cannot be said that men go to sex on premises venues for only one reason (figure 26), to have sex with another man is generally the primary reason, and by far the most common collectively.

Figure 26

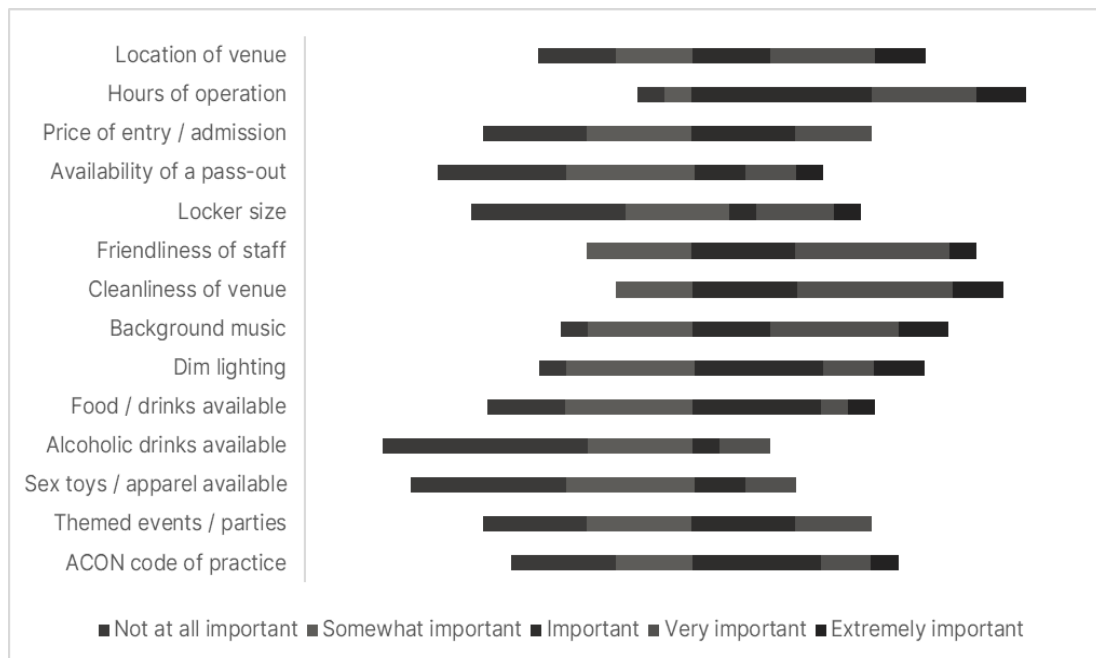
Reasons for visiting sex on premises venues



However, while men may share similar desires for connection, exploration or an encounter, the factors that influence their choice of preferred venue are varied and differ widely with regards to how important these factors are to the decision made by an individual (figure 27) when the intensity of the respondent's attitudes is measured.

Figure 27

Factors of importance in preferences of sex on premises venues



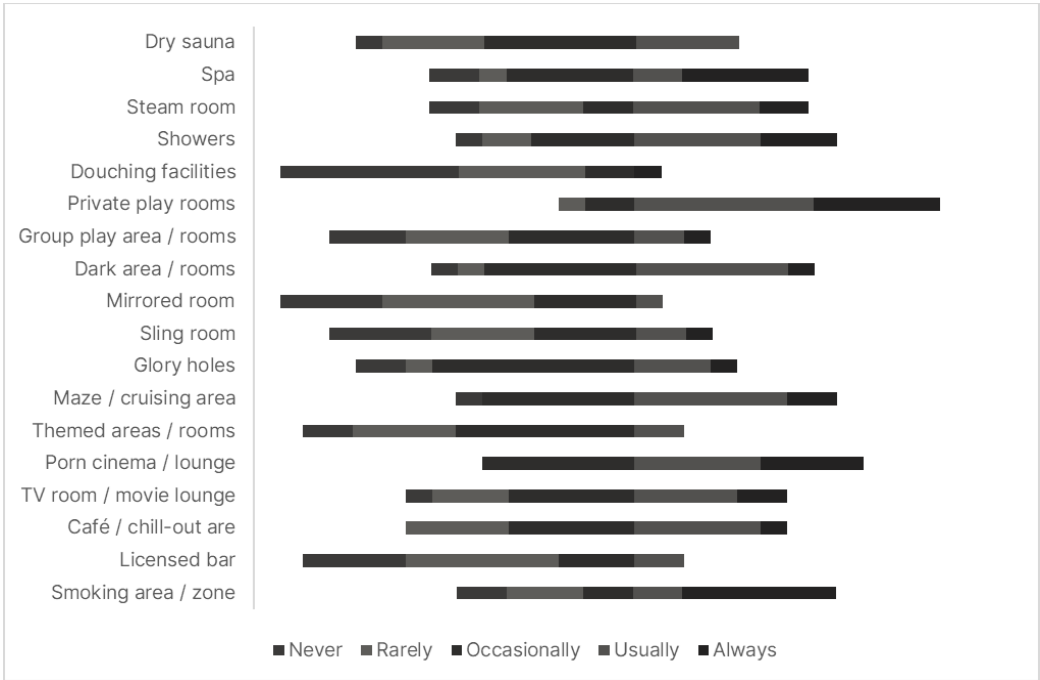
The amenities provided by sex on premises venues are essential to the customer experience but are not unique to any of the venues competing for market share in Sydney, with those that customers

favour the most (figure 28) similarly also being the amenities used by customers most frequently (figure 29) in the venues visited most often, according to the primary data collected.

Figure 28
Appeal of amenities in preferred sex on premises venues



Figure 29
Frequency of use of amenities in preferred sex on premises venues



Of the sex on premises venues visited most often, respondents were generally satisfied (figure 30) with their experience and most expressed they were likely to return to their preferred venue again in future (figure 31) and their intention to recommend their preferred venue to others was also generally highly likely (figure 32).

Figure 30

Customer satisfaction

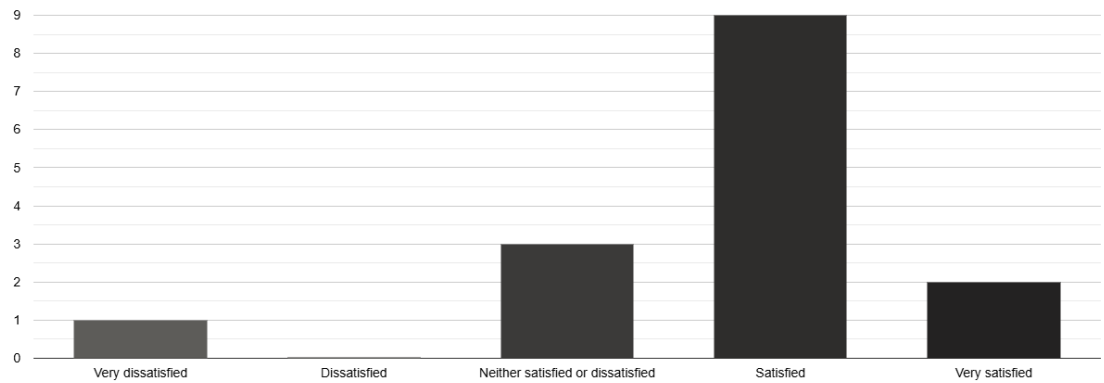


Figure 31

Intention to return

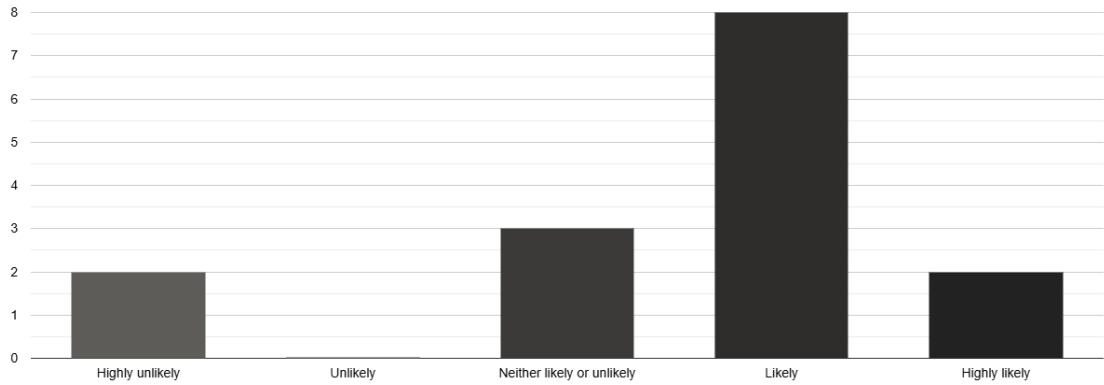
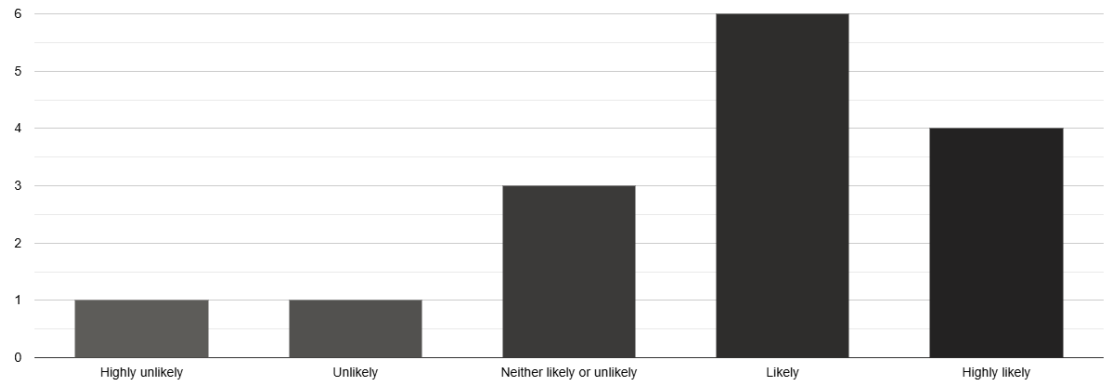


Figure 32

Intention to recommend



Understanding that these attitudes are dependent variables, to determine whether there were specific factors or particular amenities that contributed to the responses given, the primary data collected was analysed to identify any bivariate correlations with each of the factors and amenities considered as independent variables, using a mathematical formula known as the Pearson correlation coefficient (Turney, 2022).

The results of this analysis (table 1) only identified one factor with a strong relationship to customer satisfaction and two amenities with strong relationships to customers' attitudes. However, as the results were also not statistically significant, the correlations between dependent and independent variables cannot be considered to be valid relationships.

Table 1

Correlations and bivariate analysis

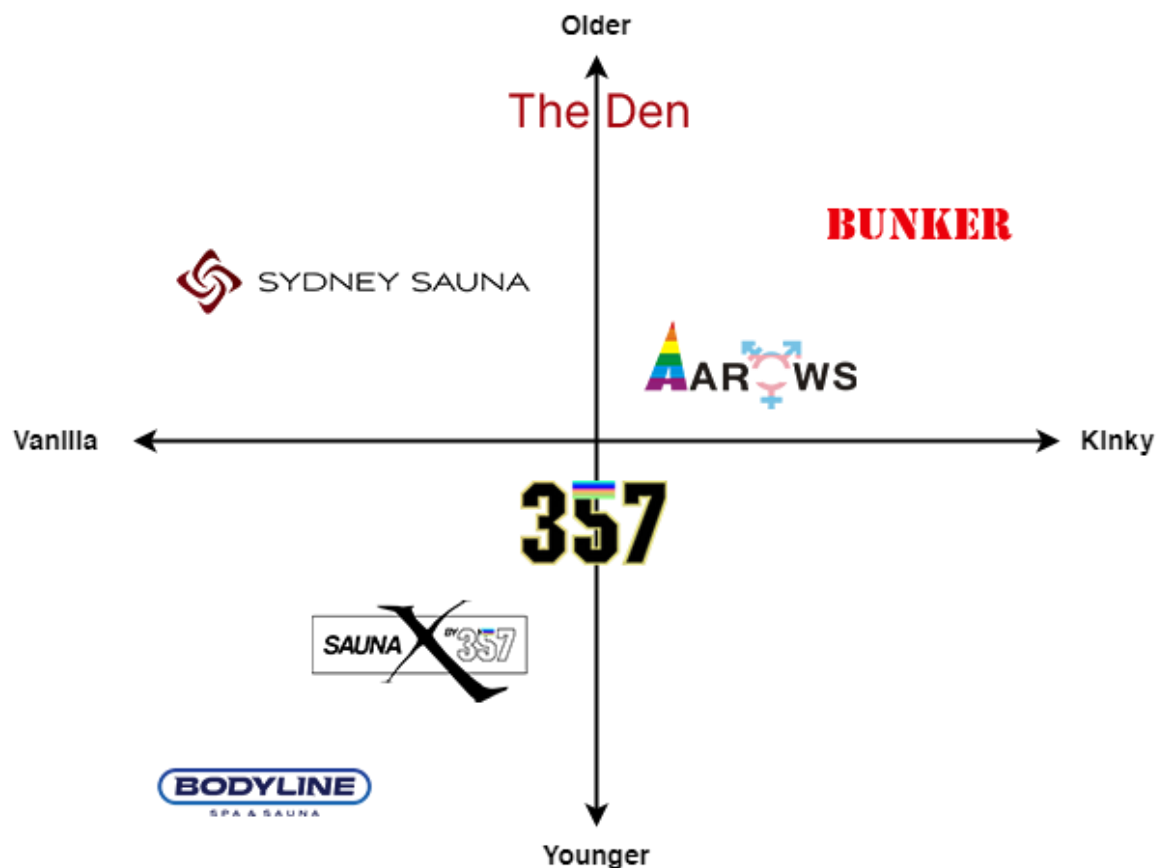
		Customer satisfaction	Intention to return	Intention to recommend
Price of entry / admission	Pearson Correlation	.504		
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.056		
Showers	Pearson Correlation	.590		
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.021		
Themed areas / rooms	Pearson Correlation	.673	.586	.556
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.006	.022	.031

Further analysis of the primary data collected was also performed to gauge whether multiple factors or amenities together influenced customers' attitudes of satisfaction, intention to return and intention to recommend, using a statistical technique known as multiple linear regression, that compares the relative importance of each independent variable's relative contribution to the value given for the dependent variables, assuming the others remain constant (Glenn, 2022). The results of the multiple regression however did not reflect that the factors important to the preference of sex on premises venue or the preferred amenities used most often in sex on premises venues, had any influence on the respondents' attitudes relating to customer satisfaction, their intention to return or their intention to recommend a venue to others.

Within the larger gay community, men not only identify as being either gay or bisexual but also belong to other tribal groups that reflect their sexual preferences, adapting both the self-expression of their individual identities and their sexual practices to align with these stereotypes. The respondents were asked to give their opinion on what types of men attended which sex on premises venues and these perceptions when mapped (figure 33) provide an insight into the market segmentation by customer of the experience economy operating within the sex services industry.

Figure 33

Perceptual map of sex on premises venues in Sydney

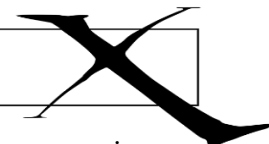


The perceptual map shows that Sauna X by 357 now occupies the space previously held by Bodyline Spa & Sauna literally but as a brand, inherits the space in the minds of customers, previously held by 357 and Bodyline Spa & Sauna as well, following the closures of the two sex on premises venues.

Finally, the internet has been searched and social media monitored for commentary by customers, to identify any failures in the delivery of the customer experience that need to be addressed by management. In the six months since taking over the site, Sauna X has taken measures to resolve the complaints around poor hygiene that had been raised about Bodyline in the past. Benefiting from the renovations that had been done prior to rebranding the sex on premises venue, customer feedback about Sauna X has been for the most part very positive, garnering a 3.8 star rating in Google reviews.

What negative criticism there is, other than a few isolated incidents, has been from 357's former customers who have complained about the size of the new location. "Cramped, not people friendly" (Trollip, 2024) and that the venue is "not as good as before, place is so small and only a few rooms and maze" (Minus, 2024) being a reflection of the poor sentiment and that the "venue is just one floor, no steam room, no 3 different cruising floors to even walk and unnecessary showers popping up on cruise areas making all floors wet with dry sauna so small only 3-5 ppl can sit at once" (Bin, 2024), remarks probably attributable to a lack of thought being given to the overall design of the servicescape since the venue's approved layout made in the development application in 1996 (appendices 3, 4 and 5).

RECOMMENDATIONS



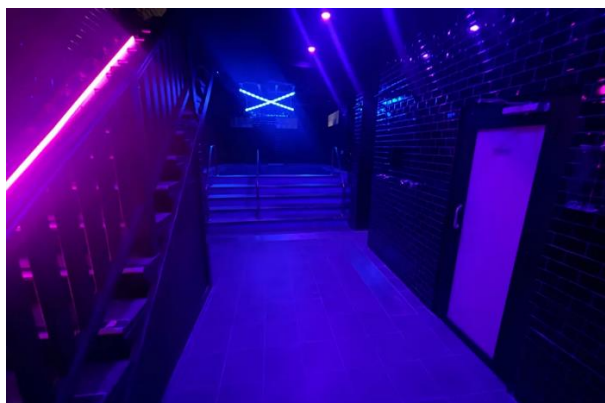
Sauna X must be congratulated for the successful turnaround in performance of the sex on premises venue however the increased attendance is largely a result of their former venue closing, reducing competition in the market with one less alternative venue for consideration by customers. In the few months that Sauna X has been open, management has taken action on the issues that had been raised about Bodyline Spa & Sauna after it had been renovated, repairing the steam room and promising further enhancements are still to come.

It would be wise for management to understand what their customers want before making any further changes to their business model though, considering that the viability of their business is heavily dependent on returning customers. Any impediments or failures in delivering a positive customer experience will ultimately result in lower attendance and reduced revenue. With this in mind, the decision to open the venue up to persons of all genders and sexualities must be scrutinised, because upon inspection of the attendance figures at Bunker, an alternative sex on premises venue on Oxford Street, it could be seen that themed events were actually a deterrent to their regular customers when compared to the attendance on days without themed events. This is likely due to the fact that a 'one size fits all' approach to running a sex on premises venue does not work for every customer, as individual tastes and desires are varied and because the intimate encounters to be had are extremely personal by their very nature. The customers of sex on premises venues prefer to shape their own experiences from the amenities provided to them by the venue rather than having any particular expectations dictated to or demanded of them in their sexual encounters.

The feedback on Sauna X is that the venue is too small and while there is little that can be done about the available space within the site, especially on the lower floor that comprises the wet areas where the spa, sauna, steam room and showers are located (figure 34), a few changes to the layout of the ground and first floors could be made to better utilise the space to meet their customers' needs.

Figure 34

Sauna X lower ground floor wet area



Note: Copyright Blackberry Group Pty Ltd 2023.

Figure 35

Sauna X ground floor cafe, lounge and bar



Note: Copyright Blackberry Group Pty Ltd 2023.

The current café and lounge area is large (figure 35), including a stage area that had been built for a DJ, along with the construction of a bar, by the previous leaseholders during the pandemic to attract customers who could not attend gay bars and clubs while the city was in lockdown. While these additions were in violation of the conditions of consent granted to the sex on premises venue by council, specifically with regards to live entertainment being prohibited inside the venue, they proved unsuccessful in practise with Bodyline Sydney still closing due to poor attendance, despite competing sex on premises venues continuing to operate, even with the COVID-19 distancing requirements in place at the time.

As the café and lounge area, including the bar, is essentially provided as a means of generating additional revenue for the business beyond its primary function of delivering sex as a service, these amenities could be smaller than the space within the servicescape they currently occupy. Similarly, the showers on the first floor (figure 36) are also not necessary, as the venue's wet areas are two floors below, where other showers are available and more suitably located to the activities in that space.

By moving the café and lounge into the area currently underutilised as a cinema, then moving the current locker room (figure 37) into that area, as well as converting the former laundry that is currently only used as storage, additional private rooms could be constructed on the ground floor (figure 38). In much the same way, additional private rooms could be constructed on the first floor (figure 39), by moving where the glory holes are currently located to the unutilised space near the stairs, as well as by removing the showers that are not a necessity to the activities in that space.

Figure 36

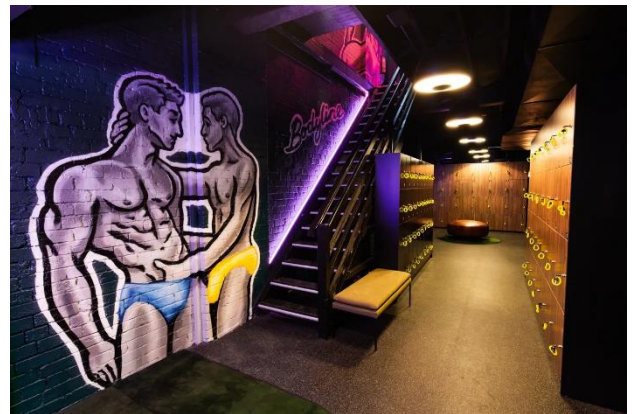
Sauna X first floor showers



Note: Copyright Blackberry Group Pty Ltd 2023.

Figure 37

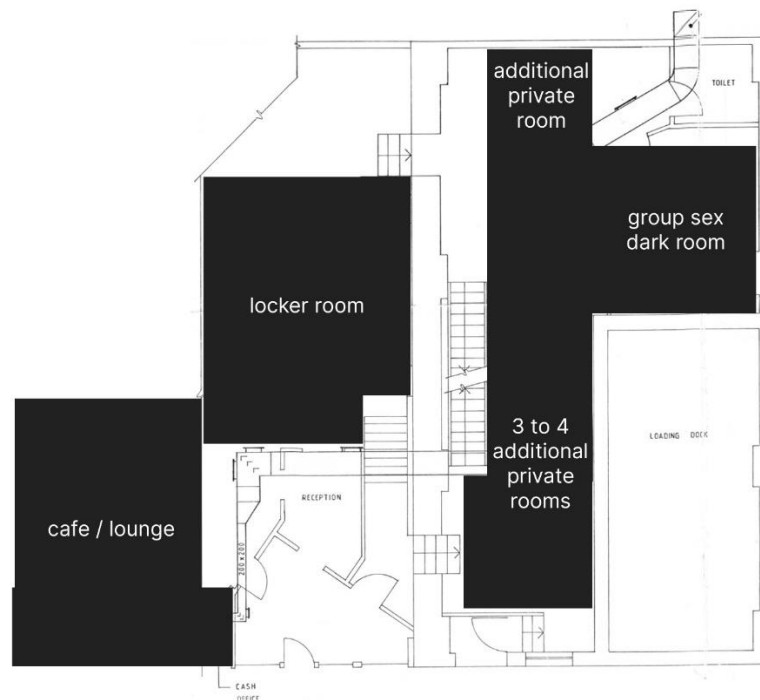
Sauna X ground floor locker room



Note: Copyright Blackberry Group Pty Ltd 2023.

Figure 38

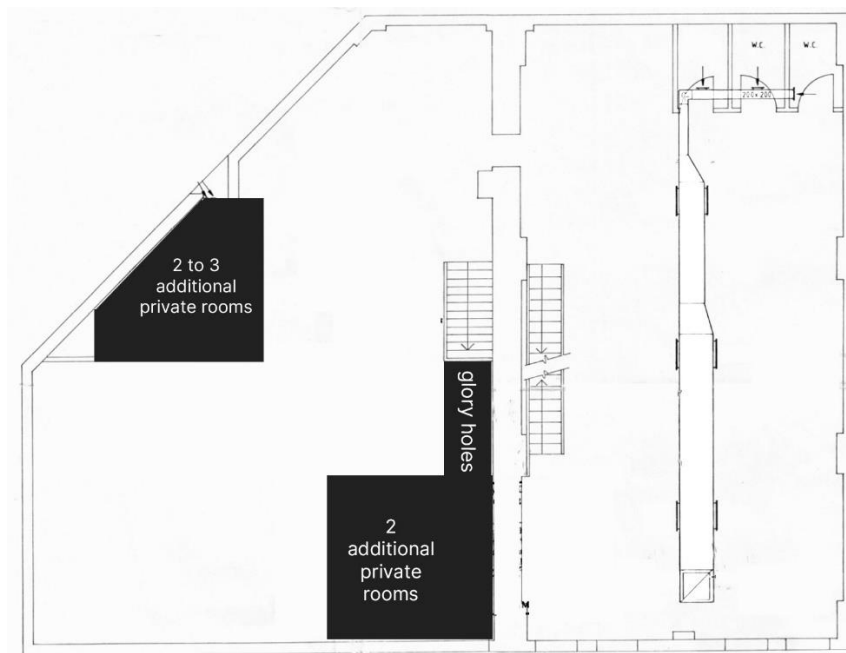
Proposed changes to Sauna X ground floor



Note: Adapted from *Bodyline Spa and Sauna: mechanical and ventilation* by ActiveAir Commercial & Industrial Mechanical Services, 1998. (<https://archives.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/nodes/view/1231412>) Copyright Robert Talbot Projects.

Figure 39

Proposed changes to Sauna X first floor



Note: Adapted from *Bodyline Spa and Sauna: mechanical and ventilation* by ActiveAir Commercial & Industrial Mechanical Services, 1998. (<https://archives.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/nodes/view/1231412>) Copyright Robert Talbot Projects.

To make such changes to the servicescape within the sex on premises venue would come at considerable expense to the business, having to also close these spaces while the construction was undertaken. Arguably, while they may improve the customer experience by providing more areas for sexual encounters to take place, the perceived difference by customers would be unlikely to result in any increase in overall attendance.

A more cost-effective recommendation would be to focus on increasing brand awareness, not only in the gay community, but across the wider community in general, particularly if the decision to cater to all genders and sexualities is an initiative that is retained. The advertising planning grid proposed by Rossiter and Percy (1991) suggests that brand awareness for a sex on premises venue is made through the combination of brand recall prior to purchase and brand attitude, that employs positive transformational motivation for a high involvement purchasing decision where search and conviction is required prior to purchase.

The tactics for increasing brand awareness and brand recall (table 2) should be implemented in advertising the sex on premises venue in an integrated campaign that includes traditional media as well as digital media, utilising the specific advertising tactics for a high involvement / transformational brand attitude (table 3) that either encompasses an emotional portrayal of the motivation or a benefit-claim support for perceived brand delivery.

Table 2

Brand awareness tactics with specific tactics for brand recall

General brand awareness tactics
Match the ad's brand awareness stimuli with the buyer response
Seek a unique advertising execution
Maximise brand awareness contact time
Specific brand recall tactics
Associate the category need and the brand in the main copy line
Keep the main copy line short
Use repetition of the main copy line for brand recall
Include a personal reference (unless it is already strong implied)
Use a bizarre execution (as long as it is appropriate to brand attitude)
Requires high media frequency relative to competitors

Note: Adapted from *Brand Awareness Tactics with Specific Tactics for Brand Recognition and Brand Recall* by J.R. Rossiter, L. Percy & R.J. Donovan, 1991.

Table 3

Advertising tactics for the high involvement / transformational brand attitude strategy

Emotional portrayal of the motivation
Emotional authenticity is paramount and should be tailored to lifestyle groups within the target audience
People must identify personally with the service as portrayed in the advertisements and not merely like the advertisements
Benefit-claim support for perceived brand delivery
Many high involvement / transformational advertisements also have to provide information
Overclaiming is recommended but don't underclaim
Repetition serves as a build-up function (often for subsequent informational advertisements) and a reinforcement function

Note: Adapted from *Advertising Tactics for the High Involvement / Transformational Brand Attitude Strategy* by J.R. Rossiter, L. Percy & R.J. Donovan, 1991.

Integrated advertising on dating apps such as Bumble and Grindr, particularly in the evenings and on weekends, is recommended to attract new customers to Sauna X, as the users of these apps share similar needs for connection and desires for sexual encounters common with the men who attend sex on premises venues.

Targeted advertising on social media, along with websites that are a source of news and event information within the gay community, such as the Star Observer, Q News and Gay Sydney News, would be effective in increasing brand awareness while simultaneously assisting to reduce the social stigma that may be acting as a deterrent to new customers in attending Sauna X for the first time.

Promotional activities in partnership with the gay bars and clubs on Oxford Street would also be an ideal avenue for increasing brand awareness. Along with advertising within the bars and clubs, through posters and drink coasters, vouchers for free admission could be given away as prizes, adding to a positive perception by their shared target audience and would also contribute to positive word of mouth in the gay community, generating a sense of excitement and uninhibited fun.

CONCLUSION

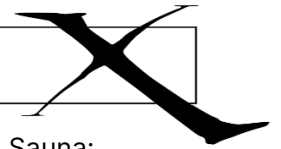


While this research project offers some recommendations for increasing attendance and opportunities for improving the customer experience at Sauna X, in alignment with its perception by customers and its points of differentiation in market segmentation among competing sex on premises venues, they are informed by rather generic insights gained about the industry at large.

The limitations of this research, having collected primary data from only a very small sample size, have meant that any particular factors of influence or trends that contribute to the preference of one sex on premises venue over any other by gay and bisexual men could not be identified.

The scope of future research that is conducted across a larger sample of the target audience and seeks to uncover not only the criteria used by men in their choice of sex on premises venues but the factors that may be acting as barriers by potential new customers, should be undertaken to better inform any future marketing strategies by this unique business model that sells sex as a service to the gay community in Sydney.

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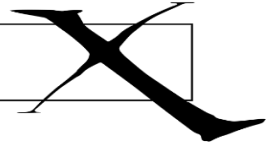


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Appendix 1

Survey landing page

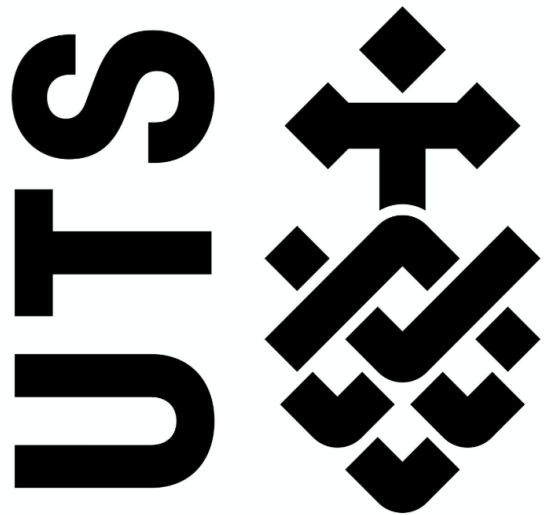
Sex On Premises Venues

This survey is being conducted by a post-graduate student at the University of Technology Sydney (UTS) as part of a capstone business project in marketing.

The objectives of this survey are to gain a deeper understanding of the reasons why men go to sex on premises venues and their needs being met, identify the servicescape factors used by sex on premises venues as points of differentiation in market segmentation and discover the relevance of these factors to the customer experience and their influence on preference of venue.

The survey should take around ten minutes to complete. The information gathered is purely for academic purposes and will be used toward the final report. Your participation is entirely voluntary and your anonymous responses will remain confidential. If you have any questions regarding this survey, please contact the subject coordinator Dr Nigel Bairstow at nigel.bairstow@uts.edu.au.

Start survey



From *Sex On Premises Venues* by L. Wyte 2024. (<http://sopv.lucaswyte.au>)

Choice of sex on premises venues

Q1

Which of the following sex on premises venues is the venue you have gone to most often in the previous 12 months? Please select one from the choices below.

- 357
- Aarows
- Bodyline
- Bunker
- The Den
- Sauna X
- Sydney Sauna
- None of these
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐

Page Break

Q2



When do you usually go to the sex on premises venue that you have gone to most often (that you answered in Q1 above)? Please select one from the choices below.

- Weekdays 12pm to 6pm
- Weeknights 6pm to 12am
- Weeknights 12am to 6am
- Weekends 6am to 6pm
- Weekends 6pm to 12am
- Weekends 12am to 6am
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐

Q3

What reason do you usually go to the sex on premises venue that you have gone to most often (that you answered in Q1 above)? Please select all that apply.

- ☐ To have sex with another man (one to one)
- ☐ To have sex with more than one man (one to many)
- ☐ To have group sex with more than one man (many to many)
- ☐ To watch others having sex (voyeurism)
- ☐ To perform for others having sex (exhibitionism)
- ☐ To watch pornography
- ☐ To participate in kink or a sexual fetish
- ☐ To relax and unwind
- ☐ To connect with other men (for company / friendship / community)
- ☐ For somewhere to go after a night out (to avoid self-isolation)

Page Break

Q4

How important were the following factors to you in selecting the sex on premises venue that you have gone to most often (that you answered in Q1 above)? Please select one response for each factor.

	Not at all important	Somewhat important	Important	Very important	Extremely important
Location of venue	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hours of operation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Price of entry / admission	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Availability of a pass-out	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Locker size	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Friendliness of staff	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Cleanliness of venue	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Background music	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Dim lighting	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Food and / or drinks available to purchase	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Alcoholic drinks available to purchase	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sex toys and / or apparel available to purchase	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Themed events and / or parties	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
ACON code of practice compliance	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



Sex on premises venue amenities

Q5

We would like to know your opinion about the amenities that may be available within a sex on premises venue. Please select the response that best describes your feeling generally about each of the amenities listed below.

	Definitely dislike	Somewhat dislike	Neither like nor dislike	Somewhat like	Definitely like
Dry sauna	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Spa	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steam room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Showers	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Douching facilities	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Private play rooms	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Group play areas / rooms	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Dark area / rooms	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Mirrored room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sling room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Glory holes	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Maze / cruising area	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Themed areas / rooms	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Porn cinema / lounge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
TV room / movie lounge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Cafe / chill-out area	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Licensed bar	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Smoking area / zone	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Q6

Now we would like to know to what extent you actually use the amenities within a sex on premises venue. Please select the response that best describes your frequency of use for each of the amenities listed below.

	Never	Rarely	Occasionally	Usually	Always
Dry sauna	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Spa	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Steam room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Showers	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Douching facilities	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Private play rooms	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Group play areas / rooms	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Dark area / rooms	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Mirrored room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sling room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Glory holes	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Maze / cruising area	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Themed areas / rooms	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Porn cinema / lounge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
TV room / movie lounge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Cafe / chill-out area	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Licensed bar	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Smoking area / zone	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



Sex on premises venue perception

Q7

A choice of three statements for two perceptions about the types of people who go to sex on premises venues are listed below. There are no right or wrong answers; we are only interested in your opinion. For each venue, please select the statement in each column that best expresses your opinion on who the venue caters to.

	Caters to men who are			Caters to sex that is more		
	Younger	Older	All ages	Vanilla	Kinky	Somewhere in-between
357	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Arrows	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Bodyline	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Bunker	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The Den	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sauna X	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sydney Sauna	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



Sex on premises venue satisfaction

Q8



How satisfied are you with the sex on premises venue that you have gone to most often (that you answered in Q1 above)? Please select the response that most closely represents your satisfaction.

Very dissatisfied

☐

Dissatisfied

☐

Neither satisfied nor dissatisfied

☐

Satisfied

☐

Very satisfied

☐

Q9



How likely are you to return to the sex on premises venue that you have gone to most often (that you answered in Q1 above)? Please select the response that most closely represents the likelihood.

Highly unlikely

☐

Unlikely

☐

Neither likely nor unlikely

☐

Likely

☐

Highly likely

☐

Q10

How likely are you to recommend to a friend the sex on premises venue that you have gone to most often (that you answered in Q1 above)? Please select the response that most closely represents the likeliness.

Highly unlikely Unlikely Neither likely nor unlikely Likely Highly likely

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐



▼ Comments about sex on premises venues

Q11

Would you like to make any other comments about sex on premises venues?



▼ Demographics

Q12

What is your gender?

Male Female Trans Non-binary Prefer not to say

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

Q13

What is your sexuality?

Straight Gay Bi Trans Other Prefer not to say

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

Q14

What is your marital / relationship status?

- | | | | | | |
|-----------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|
| Single | In a monogamous relationship | In an open relationship | In a monogamous marriage | In an open marriage | Prefer not to say |
| ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |

Q15

What is your age?

- | | | | | | | | | |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|
| Under 18 | 18 - 24 | 25 - 34 | 35 - 44 | 45 - 54 | 55 - 64 | 65 - 74 | 75 - 84 | 85 or older |
| ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |



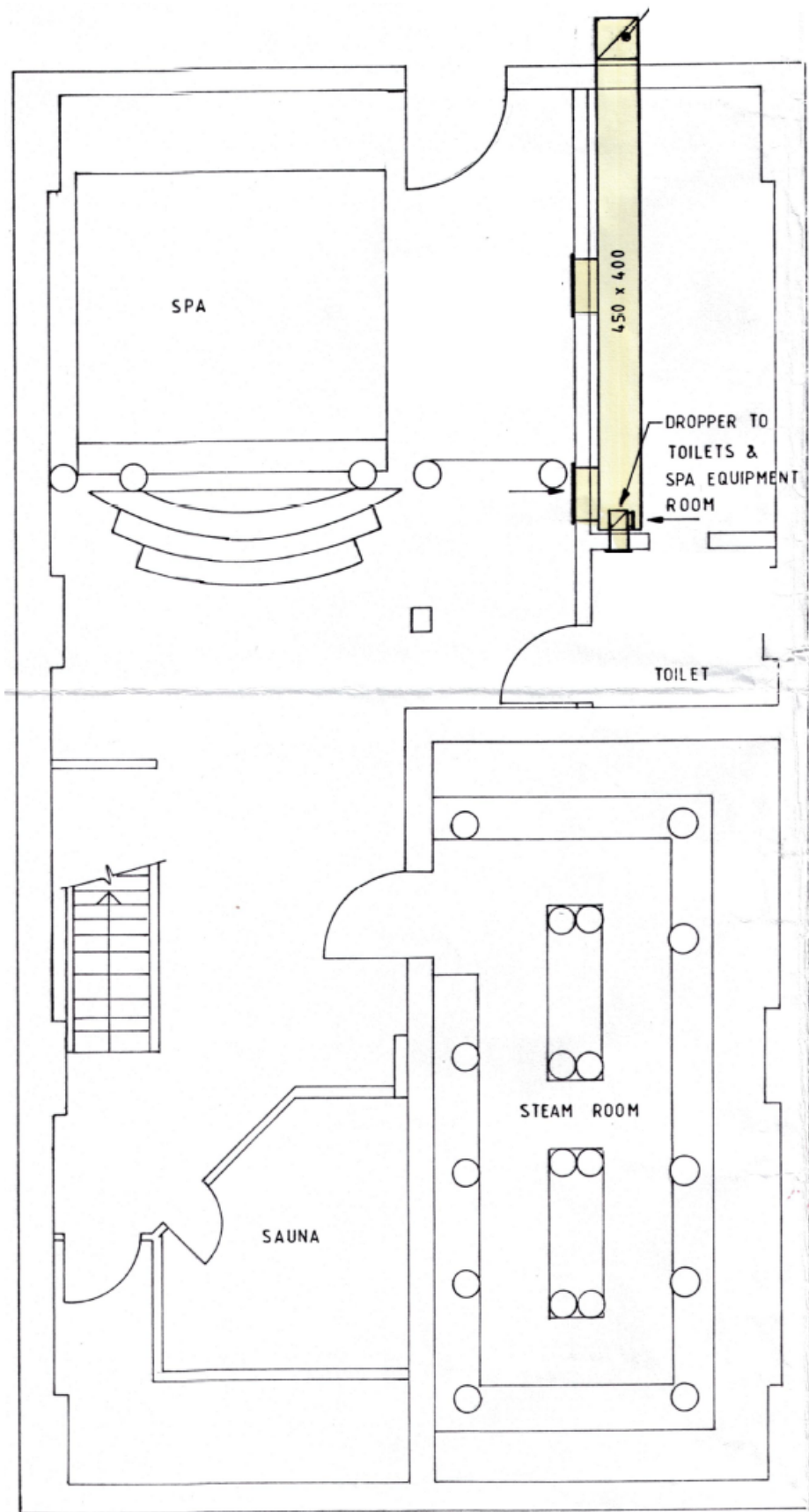
End of Survey

Your participation in this survey is appreciated.

From *Sex on Premises Venues* by L. Wyte 2024. (https://utsau.au1.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_ey3LMXz1tVkW8dw)

Appendix 3

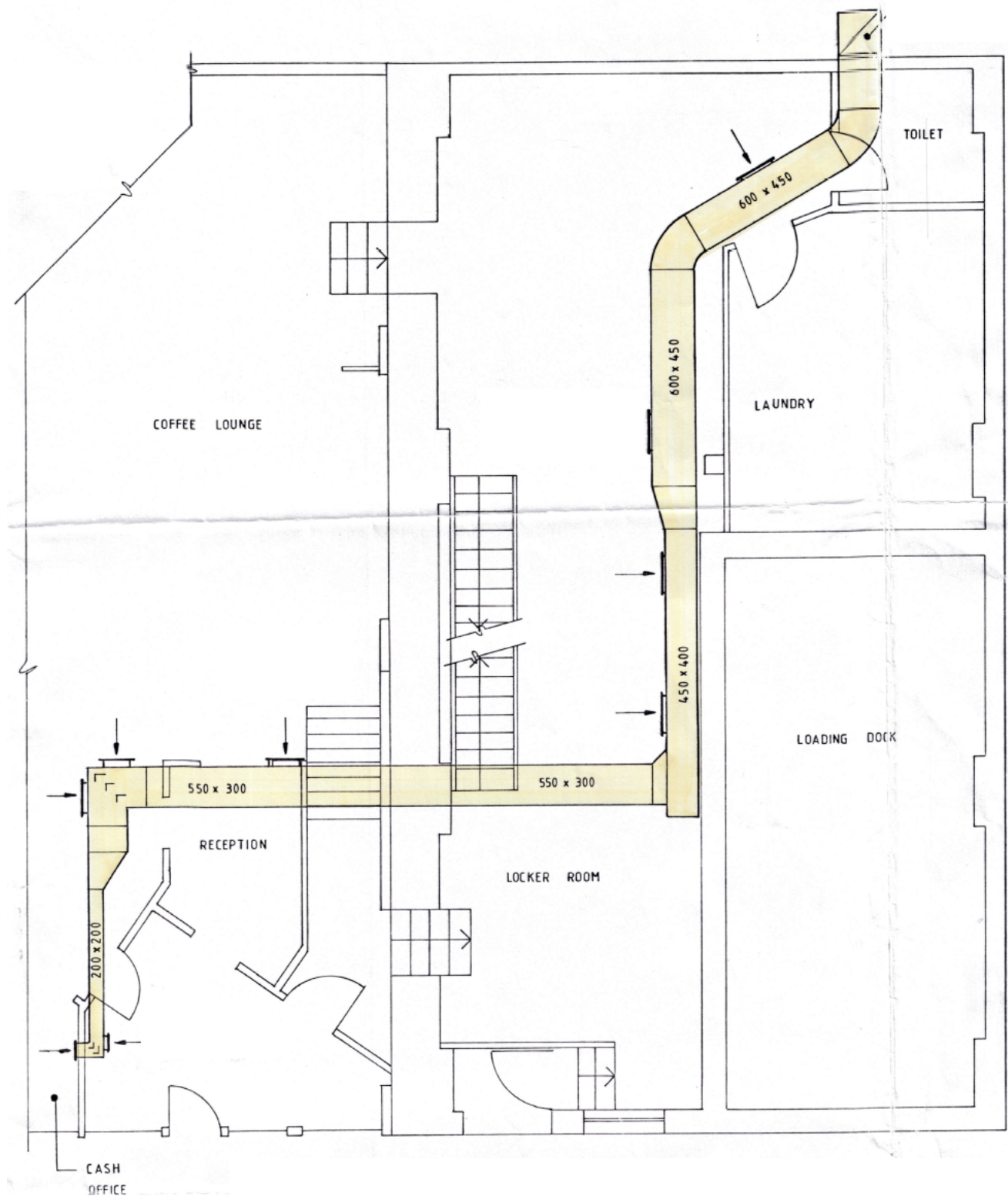
Basement floor plan



Note: From *Bodyline Spa and Sauna: mechanical and ventilation* by ActiveAir Commercial & Industrial Mechanical Services, 1998. (<https://archives.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/nodes/view/1231412>) Copyright Robert Talbot Projects.

Appendix 4

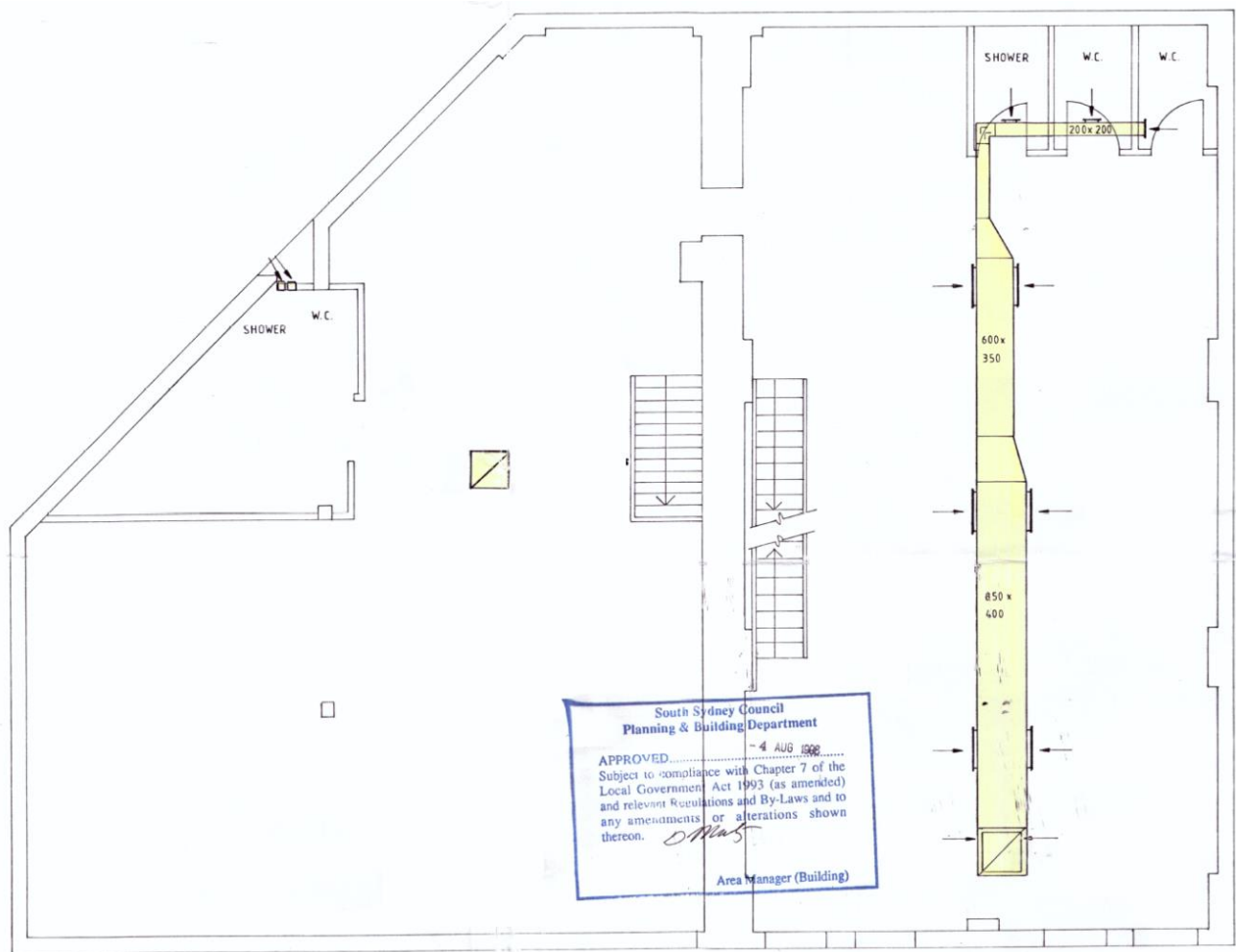
Ground floor plan



Note: From *Bodyline Spa and Sauna: mechanical and ventilation* by ActiveAir Commercial & Industrial Mechanical Services, 1998. (<https://archives.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/nodes/view/1231412>) Copyright Robert Talbot Projects.

Appendix 5

First floor plan



Note: From *Bodyline Spa and Sauna: mechanical and ventilation* by ActiveAir Commercial & Industrial Mechanical Services, 1998. (<https://archives.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/nodes/view/1231412>) Copyright Robert Talbot Projects.